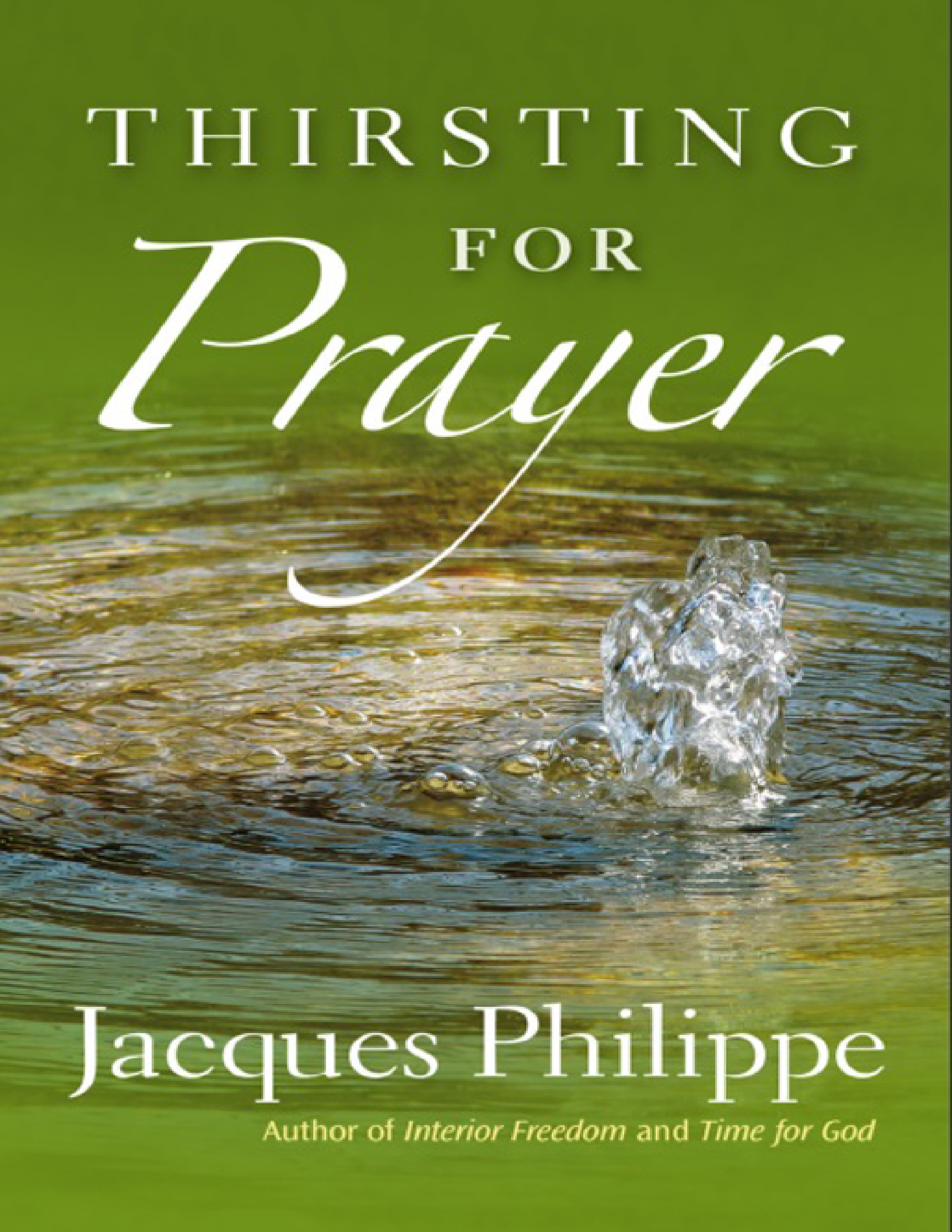
THIRSTING FOR *Prayer*



Jacques Philippe

Author of *Interior Freedom* and *Time for God*

THIRSTING
FOR
Prayer

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Scepter

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P.O. Box 1391
New Rochelle, NY 10801
www.scepterpublishers.org

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Translated by Helena Scott
Text and cover design by Rose Design

Printed in the United States of America

ISBN: 978-159417-208-3

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INTRODUCTION

There are plenty of excellent books about prayer. Is there honestly any need for another one? Not really. I have already written a book on this subject[1] some years ago, and I was not planning to write another. However, in spite of the risk of repeating myself on certain points, I recently felt impelled to write this present book, in the hope that it could help certain people to persevere along the path of personal prayer or to start out on it. I often go to preach retreats in many different countries, and I am struck by the thirst for prayer that is apparent today among so many people from every different walk of life and every kind of calling; but also by the need that exists for definite signposts to ensure their perseverance and the fruitfulness of their prayer life.

What the world most needs today is prayer. It is prayer that will give birth to all the renewals, healings, deep and fruitful transformations we all want for society today. This world of ours is very sick, and only contact with heaven will be able to cure it. The most useful thing for the Church to do today is to give people a thirst for prayer and teach them to pray.

Helping people to acquire a taste for prayer, helping them to persevere on the path of prayer, which is not always an easy one, is the biggest gift one can give them. Those who have prayer have everything, because on that basis God can freely enter their lives and act in them, working the marvels of his grace. I am more and more convinced that everything comes from prayer and that, among the calls of the Spirit, this is the first and most urgent one we should respond to. To be renewed in prayer is to be renewed in all the aspects of our lives, to find a new youthfulness. More than ever, God the Father is seeking those who will worship him in Spirit and in truth (cf. Jn 4:24).

In this field, obviously, we don’t all have the same call or the same possibilities. But we should do what we can, for God will be faithful. I know lay people fully taken up by their family and work commitments who in twenty minutes of daily prayer receive as many graces as monks who pray for five hours a day. God so urgently desires to reveal himself, to show

his fatherly face to all of us, poor and little as we are, so that he can be our light, our healing, our happiness. And this is especially true given that the world we live in is such a difficult one.

It is always useful to talk about prayer, because it involves the most important aspects of the spiritual life and also of human life.

I would like, then, in this book, to offer some very simple suggestions, within everyone's grasp, to encourage those who wish to respond to this call and guide them in their development, so that the deep inner encounter with God which is the aim of prayer may take place. So that they may find effectively, in their faithfulness to prayer, the strength and peace they need for their lives to bear fruit in abundance, as our Lord desires.

I shall be talking essentially about personal prayer. Communal prayer, especially participation in the Church's liturgy, is a basic dimension of Christian life, and it is not my intention to undervalue it. However, I shall speak mainly about personal prayer, because that is where people generally encounter most difficulties. What's more, without personal prayer, communal prayer risks being merely superficial and not having all its beauty and value. A liturgical and sacramental life that is not nourished by a personal encounter with God and is not at the service of that encounter can become tedious and sterile.

The world is going through difficult times, and they may perhaps become more difficult still. All the more reason for us to be deeply rooted in prayer, as Jesus invites us in the Gospel:

> Watch at all times, praying that you may have strength to escape all these things that will take place, and to stand before the Son of man (Lk 21:36).

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1. *Time for God* (New York: Scepter Publishers, 2008).

CHAPTER I

What Is at Stake in Prayer

Our lives are worth what our prayer is worth.

—MARTHE ROBIN

Faithfulness and perseverance in prayer (the fundamental points to establish and the main objective of our fight in prayer) demand powerful motivation. We need to be firmly convinced that even though the path is not always easy, it is worthwhile starting out on it, and the positive aspects of this faithfulness are out of all proportion to the efforts we make and the difficulties we will inevitably encounter. In this first chapter, I want to talk about the main reasons why we "ought always to pray and not lose heart," as Jesus invites us to do in the Gospel (cf. Lk 18:1).

To begin with, here is a quotation from St. Peter of Alcantara, a sixteenth-century Franciscan who was a great support to St. Teresa of Avila in her reform. It is taken from his *Treatise on Prayer and Meditation*, and he in turn attributes it to St. Lawrence Justinian, *In Signo Vitae*:

> In prayer the soul is purified from sin, charity is nurtured, faith takes root, hope is strengthened, the spirit gladdened. In prayer the soul melts into tenderness, the heart is purified, the truth reveals itself, temptation is overcome, sadness is put to flight. In prayer, the senses are renewed, lukewarmness vanishes, failing virtue is reinvigorated, the rust of vices is scoured away; and in this exchange, there come forth living sparks, blazing desires of heaven, in which the flame of divine love burns.

I don't want to comment on this passage, but just offer it as a stimulating testimony to an experience in which we can put our full trust. Perhaps we will not find the same thing perceptibly every day, but if we are faithful, little by little we will experience that everything promised in this beautiful passage is absolutely true.

Now I turn to a more recent witness, our blessed Pope John Paul II, in his Apostolic Letter *Novo Millennio Ineunte*. This letter was addressed to all the faithful and published on January 6, 2001, at the end of the Jubilee Year by which the Pope wished to prepare the Church to enter the third millennium, exhorting us to "put out into deep water" (Lk 5:4).

In this letter, the Pope reviewed the Jubilee Year and then invited us to contemplate the face of Christ, “treasure and joy of the Church,” offering an inspiring meditation on the mystery of Jesus, which should light up the journey of each of the faithful. In the third part of the letter he exhorted us to “start afresh from Christ” to face the challenges of the third millennium. While leaving it up to each local church to set out its own pastoral goals, he suggested certain basic points valid for the whole Church. He recalled that every pastoral program should essentially enable each Christian to respond to the call to holiness that comes with our baptismal calling, quoting the words of Vatican II:

> All the Christian faithful, of whatever state or rank, are called to the fullness of the Christian life and to the perfection of charity (*Lumen Gentium*, 40).

The first thing needed in order to put a genuine “training in holiness” in place in the life of the Church must be training in prayer. As John Paul II tells us:

> This training in holiness calls for a Christian life distinguished above all in the art of prayer. The Jubilee Year has been a year of more intense prayer, both personal and communal. But we well know that prayer cannot be taken for granted. We have to learn to pray: as it were learning this art ever anew from the lips of the Divine Master himself, like the first disciples: “Lord, teach us to pray!” (Lk 11:1). Prayer develops that conversation with Christ which makes us his intimate friends: “Abide in me and I in you” (Jn 15:4). This reciprocity is the very substance and soul of the Christian life, and the condition of all true pastoral life. Wrought in us by the Holy Spirit, this reciprocity opens us, through Christ and in Christ, to contemplation of the Father’s face. Learning this Trinitarian shape of Christian prayer and living it fully, above all in the liturgy, the summit and source of the Church’s life, but also in personal experience, is the secret of a truly vital Christianity, which has no reason to fear the future, because it returns continually to the sources and finds in them new life.[1]

In this beautiful passage, John Paul II reminds us of some essential points: prayer is the soul of Christian life, and the pre-condition for all genuine pastoral activity. Prayer makes us into friends of God, introduces us into intimacy with him and draws us into the richness of his life, bringing us to live in him, and bringing him to live in us. Without that reciprocal exchange of love which prayer brings about, the Christian religion is merely empty formalism, the announcing of the Gospel is just propaganda, and charitable commitment is just social work that does not make any fundamental change in the condition of mankind.

Another statement of the Pope’s which I find very true and very important is that prayer is “the secret of a truly vital Christianity, which has no reason to fear the future.” Prayer enables us to draw from God a life that

is ever new, to let ourselves be continually reborn and renewed. Whatever our trials and disappointments, harsh situations, failures, and faults, prayer makes us rediscover enough strength and hope to take up our lives again with total confidence in the future. This is something that is really necessary today!

A little further on, John Paul II refers to the thirst for spirituality so much in evidence in today's world; a thirst that is often ambiguous, but that is also an opportunity; and he shows how the Church's tradition offers a genuine response to this thirst:

The great mystical tradition of the Church of both East and West has much to say in this regard. It shows how prayer can progress, as a genuine dialogue of love, to the point of rendering the person wholly possessed by the divine Beloved, vibrating at the Spirit's touch, resting filially within the Father's heart. This is the lived experience of Christ's promise: "He who loves me will be loved by my Father, and I will love him and manifest myself to him" (Jn 14:21).

He goes on to say how important it is for every Christian community (family, parish, charismatic group, Catholic Action group, etc.) to be above all a place of educating in prayer:

Yes, dear brothers and sisters, our Christian communities must become genuine "schools" of prayer, where the meeting with Christ is expressed not just in imploring help but also in thanksgiving, praise, adoration, contemplation, listening, and ardent devotion, until the heart truly "falls in love." Intense prayer, yes, but it does not distract us from our commitment to history: by opening our heart to the love of God it also opens it to the love of our brothers and sisters, and makes us capable of shaping history according to God's plan.

This call to prayer is addressed to everyone, including lay people. If lay people do not pray, or are content with merely superficial prayer, they are in danger.

It would be wrong to think that ordinary Christians can be content with a shallow prayer that is unable to fill their whole life. Especially in the face of the many trials to which today's world subjects faith, they would be not only mediocre Christians but "Christians at risk." They would run the insidious risk of seeing their faith progressively undermined, and would perhaps end up succumbing to the allure of "substitutes," accepting alternative religious proposals and even indulging in far-fetched superstitions.

And, accordingly, he concludes:

It is therefore essential that education in prayer should become in some way a key point of all pastoral planning.

1. Prayer as a response to a call

The first thing that should motivate us and encourage us to enter into a life of prayer is that God himself is inviting us to do it. Man searches for God, but God seeks out man even more actively. God calls us to pray to him, because right from the start, and far more than we can imagine, he ardently desires to enter into communion with us.

The firmest base for our prayer life is not our seeking, or our personal initiative, or our desire (these things are valuable, but they may sometimes be lacking). The firmest foundation is God's call: "Pray without ceasing!" (see 1 Thes 5:17), "Watch and pray!" (Mt 26:41), "Pray at all times!" (Eph 6:18).

We do not pray because we desire God or because we expect valuable gifts from our prayer life, but first and foremost because it is God who asks us to. And in asking us to pray, he knows what he is doing. His plans are infinitely beyond anything we can glimpse, desire or imagine. In prayer there is a mystery that absolutely surpasses our understanding. What drives a prayer life is faith—faith as trusting obedience to God's proposal. And we cannot even imagine the immense positive repercussions of this humble, trusting response to God's call; just like Abraham, who set out without knowing where he was going, and so became the father of a whole nation.

If we pray for the sake of the benefits we hope to obtain from prayer, we risk becoming discouraged at some stage. The benefits are neither instantaneous nor measurable. If we pray in an attitude of humble submission to God's word, we will always have the grace to persevere. This is what Marthe Robin said:

> I want to be faithful, very faithful to prayer every day, in spite of all the dryness, boredom, or distaste that I may encounter … in spite of the unpleasant, discouraging, threatening things the devil may tell me! … On days of trouble and torment, I will tell myself: God wants this, my vocation requires this, and that's enough for me! I will do the prayer, I will keep at it for the whole time I have been told to, I will do the prayer as well as I can, and when it is time to stop, I will say to God boldly: "My God, I haven't prayed, I haven't worked, I've done nothing, but I've obeyed you. I've suffered a lot, but I've shown you that I love you and want to love you."

This attitude of loving, trusting obedience is the most fruitful thing of all. Our prayer life will be rich and beneficial to the degree that it is inspired, not by a desire to obtain anything, but by this approach of a confident, obedient response to God's call. God knows what is good for us, and that should be enough for us. We ought not to take a utilitarian view of prayer, reducing it to questions of results and profits; that would distort it completely. We don't have to justify to anyone else the time we spend on

prayer. God invites us, so to speak, to “waste time” on him, and that is enough.

It will be a “fruitful waste,” in the words of St. Thérèse of Lisieux.[2] There is an aspect of gratuitousness which is absolutely essential in any prayer life. Paradoxically, the more our prayer is gratuitous—done freely, not to get something out of it—the more it will bear fruit. What we need to do is entrust ourselves to God to the extent of doing whatever he asks of us, without feeling any need for further reasons. “Do whatever he tells you” (Jn 2:5), Mary says to the servants at the wedding feast at Cana.

Always keeping in mind this principle of gratuitousness, I now nevertheless want to talk about a number of reasons that do justify the time we dedicate to prayer. St. John of the Cross says, “The person who flees prayer is fleeing everything that is good.”[3] Let’s look at why.

2. God comes first in our lives

Human life only finds its full balance and beauty when God is at its center. “Serve God first!” said St. Joan of Arc. Faithfulness to prayer is what effectively ensures that we can give this central place to God in specific ways. Without faithfulness to prayer, giving priority to God risks being nothing more than a good intention, or even an illusion. If we do not pray, we will subtly but surely put our own egos at the center of our lives, instead of the living God. We will be distracted by a huge number of different desires, demands, and fears. By contrast, if we do pray, even though we have to fight against the weight of our own egos and our habits of self-centeredness and selfishness, we will find that we are working in the direction of detachment from ourselves and re-centering on God that little by little gives him (or restores him to) the right place—the first place—in our lives. And in this way we discover the unity and consistency of our lives. “He who does not gather with me scatters” (Lk 11:23). When God is at the center, everything else falls into place.

Giving God absolute first place in relation to every other reality (work, relationships, etc.) is the only way of establishing a right relationship to things that involves a genuine investment and a healthy detachment enabling us to safeguard our inner freedom and the unity of our lives. Otherwise we fall into indifference and carelessness or, just the opposite, into dependency, invasiveness, distraction, and needless anguish.

The link between God and ourselves established when we pray is also a basic element of stability in our lives. God is the Rock, whose love is unshakable, “the Father of lights with whom there is no shadow or variation due to change” (Jas 1:17). In a world as unstable as ours, with its rapid rate of change that renders electronic devices obsolete in barely a year, it is all the more important to find our inner support in God. Prayer teaches us to put down our roots in God, to “abide in his love” (Jn 15:9), to find strength and security in him, thus empowering us in turn to become stable supports for others.

What is more, God is the only source of inexhaustible energy. By prayer, “though our outer nature is wasting away, our inner nature is renewed every day,” as St. Paul says (2 Cor 4:16). We can also remember the words of the prophet Isaiah:

> Even youths shall faint and be weary, and young men shall fall exhausted; but they who wait for the Lord shall renew their strength, they shall mount up with wings like eagles, they shall run and not be weary, they shall walk and not faint (Is 40:30–31).

Of course we will have times of trial and weariness in our lives, since we need to experience our weakness and know that we are poor and small. Nevertheless, it is still true that in prayer God is able to give us the energy, sometimes including physical energy, that we need to serve him and love him.

3. Loving freely, not for what we get out of it

Faithfulness to prayer is extremely valuable because it helps us preserve the element of gratuitousness in our lives. As I said earlier, praying means wasting our time for God. Basically this is an attitude of loving freely, and not for our own benefit. This idea of gratuitousness is endangered today, when everything is evaluated by profitability, results, and performance. That ends up by being destructive for human life.

True love cannot be reduced to the category of what is useful. In telling of our Lord’s instituting the twelve Apostles, the Gospel of Mark says Jesus chose them first of all “to be with him” (Mk 3:14). And only after that, to share his work: to preach, cast out devils, etc. We are not merely servants, we are called to be friends, sharing his life and being close to him, over and above any question of usefulness. This takes us right back to the beginning,

when, in the cool of the day, God wanted to walk in the Garden of Eden with Adam and Eve (cf. Gn 3:8). I love one of the things God said to Sister Marie of the Trinity,[4] calling her to a life of totally gratuitous prayer, of adoration and pure receptivity. He told her, “It’s easier to find laborers to work, than children to play.”[5]

To pray is to spend time freely with God just for the joy of being together. It is to love, because giving our time means giving our lives. Love does not mean primarily to do something for the other person, it means being there with them. Prayer trains us to be there with God, in a simple act of loving attention.

The marvel of it is that as we learn to be there with God alone, we learn by that very fact to be there for other people. People with a long-established prayer life possess a noticeable quality of attention, presence, listening, and availability, which people whose whole lives are given over to activity are often incapable of. Prayer gives rise to sensitivity, respect, and attention, precious gifts for those whom we encounter on our way.

There is no more beautiful and effective school of attention to our neighbor than perseverance in prayer. It would make no sense to set prayer in opposition to or in conflict with love of neighbor.

4. A foretaste of the Kingdom

Prayer gives us a foretaste of heaven. It makes us glimpse and savor a happiness that is not of this world, and that nothing here below can give us: the happiness in God for which we are destined, for which we were created. Yes, we do encounter struggles, sufferings, and aridity in our prayer lives—and I’ll come back to this. But if we persevere faithfully in prayer, we taste from time to time an inexpressible happiness: a degree of peace and fulfillment that are a real foretaste of paradise. “You will see heaven opened,” Jesus has promised us (Jn 1:51).

The first rule of the Brothers of Our Lady of Mount Carmel, founded in the Holy Land in the twelfth century, invites them to “meditate day and night on the law of the Lord,” with this aim: “To taste in a certain manner in our hearts, to experience in our minds the strength of the divine presence and the sweetness of the glory on high, not only after death but even in this mortal life.”[6] St. Teresa of Avila takes up the same idea in *The Interior Castle*:

Since some foretaste of heaven may be enjoyed by us on earth, let us beg our Lord earnestly to help us with his grace so that we do not forgo it through our own fault. Let us beg Him to show us the path to it, and to give us the strength of soul to uncover this hidden treasure, since it truly lies within us.[7]

Prayer gives us access to the realities proclaimed by St. Paul:

No eye has seen, nor ear heard, nor the heart of man conceived, what God has prepared for those who love him (1 Cor 2:9).

This also means that in prayer we learn here on earth what our activity and delight will be for all eternity: to rejoice totally in the beauty of God and the glory of the Kingdom. We learn to do what we were created for. We bring into play the best and deepest faculties with which we are endowed as human beings and which all too often remain underused: our powers of adoration, wonder, praise, and thanksgiving. We recover the heart and eyes of a child, to wonder at the Beauty beyond all beauty, the Love that surpasses all love.

Praying, then, also means fulfilling ourselves as human beings, in accordance with the deepest powers of our nature and the most secret desires of our hearts. We will not experience this in a perceptible way every day, of course, but all those who commit themselves, with fidelity and good will, to the path of prayer, will experience something of it, at least at certain times of grace. This is especially true today. There is so much ugliness, evil, and sadness in our world that God, who is faithful and wants to reawaken our hope, does not fail to reveal to his children the treasures of his Kingdom. St. John of the Cross said in the sixteenth century:

God has always revealed to mortals the treasures of his wisdom and his spirit, but now that malice is showing its face more, God is revealing these treasures much more.[8]

What would he say today!

Personally, I am astonished at some of the graces of prayer being received today by many people, including very simple lay people during weekly Eucharistic adoration in their local churches. It does not get into the newspapers, but there is genuine mystical life in the People of God, especially in the poor and the little ones.

Jesus rejoiced in the Holy Spirit and said, “I thank thee, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, that thou hast hidden these things from the wise and understanding and revealed them to babes; yea, Father, for such was thy gracious will” (Lk 10:21).

Observe this beautiful fact: By bringing us into communion with God, prayer makes us share in God's creativity. Contemplation nourishes our creative faculties and our inventiveness, particularly in the realm of beauty. Contemporary art is cruelly lacking in inspiration and very often produces nothing but painful ugliness, when people are so thirsty for beauty. Only a renewal of faith and prayer will enable artists to rediscover the sources of true creativity, so that they will once again be able to provide people with the beauty they so badly need, as was done by Fra Angelico, Rembrandt, or Johann Sebastian Bach.

5. Knowing God and knowing ourselves

One of the fruits of prayer is that it gives us a progressively deeper knowledge of God and ourselves. There is much that could be said about this, and a rich spiritual tradition on this subject does indeed exist among spiritual writers. I can only speak about it briefly here.

Prayer introduces us little by little into a real knowledge of God. Not an abstract, distant God, Voltaire's "watchmaker," or the god of the learned men and sages. Not even the God who is the product of a particular type of cold, cerebral theologizing. The God we come to know in prayer is the personal God, the living and true God, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ; the God who speaks to the heart, as Pascal expressed it. Not a God regarding whom we can content ourselves with some ideas received from our education or inherited from our culture, nor yet a God who is the product of our own psychological projections, but the true God.

Prayer enables us to go beyond our ideas about God, beyond the ways in which we represent him to ourselves (which are always wrong or too narrow), to arrive at an experience of God. That is something very different. In the book of Job we find this beautiful sentence:

I had heard of thee by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees thee! (Jb 42:5).

The main aim of this personal revelation of God, the essential fruit of prayer, is to know him as Father. Through Christ, in the light of the Holy Spirit, God reveals himself as Father. The passage from St. Luke, quoted earlier, in which Jesus rejoices at the revelation hidden from the wise and understanding and shown to the little ones, continues in these words:

All things have been delivered to me by my Father; and no one knows who the Son is except the Father, or who the Father is except the Son and anyone to whom the Son chooses to reveal him (Lk 10:22).

These words show clearly that the object of this revelation is the mystery of God as Father. God as inexhaustible source of life, as Origin, as never-failing gift, as generosity, and God as goodness, tenderness, and infinite mercy. The very beautiful passage in the book of Jeremiah, chapter 31, which announces the New Covenant, ends with these words:

This is the covenant which I will make with the house of Israel after those days, says the Lord: I will put my law within them, and I will write it upon their hearts; and I will be their God, and they shall be my people. And no longer shall each man teach his neighbor and each his brother, saying, 'Know the Lord,' for they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest, says the Lord; for I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more (Jer 31:33–34).

This passage beautifully combines the granting of the knowledge of God to everyone with the outpouring of his mercy, his forgiveness.

God is known in his greatness, his transcendence, his majesty, and his infinite power, but at the same time in his tenderness, his nearness, his gentleness, his endless mercy. This knowledge is not confined to the intellect but is a living experience of the whole of our being.

The giving of the knowledge of God to everyone in the messianic times is also announced in very evocative terms by the prophet Isaiah:

The earth shall be full of the knowledge of the Lord as the waters cover the sea (Is 11:9).

Knowledge of God also gives us access to true knowledge of ourselves. We human beings can only know ourselves truly in the light of God. Everything we may learn about ourselves by human means (experience of life, psychology, human sciences) is not to be despised, obviously. But that provides only a limited and partial knowledge of our being. We have access to our deepest identity only in the light of God, as we appear to the eyes of our heavenly Father.

This knowledge has two aspects: one is initially negative but leads directly into something extremely positive. I shall speak of this more fully later on, but here I want to say just a few words.

The negative aspect has to do with our sin, our deep-seated wretchedness. We only know these things truthfully in the light of God. Face to face with him, there is no longer any possible room for lies; no evasion, no excuse, no mask. We are compelled to recognize who we are,

with our wounds, our weaknesses, our inconsistencies, selfishness, hard-heartedness, secret complicity with evil, and all the rest.

It is no small thing to be exposed to the Word of God:

> The word of God is living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing to the division of soul and spirit, of joints and marrow, and discerning the thoughts and intentions of the heart. And before him no creature is hidden, but all are open and laid bare to the eyes of him with whom we have to do (Heb 4:12–13).

Happily, God is tender and merciful, and this laying bare only takes place gradually, as we become progressively more able to endure it. God only shows us our sin while revealing his forgiveness and mercy at the same time. We discover the sadness of our sinful condition, but also our absolute poverty as creatures: we have nothing except what we have received from God, and if we have received it, it is by pure grace, so that we can attribute nothing at all to ourselves nor take glory in anything whatever.

This stage of truthfulness is necessary. There can be no healing unless the sickness is known. Only the truth sets us free. Fortunately, however, the process does not stop there. It goes on to something still deeper and infinitely more beautiful: Over and above our sins and failings, we discover that we are God's children. God loves us as we are, with an absolutely unconditional love, and it is this love that gives us our deepest identity.

At a deeper and still more essential level than our human limitations and the evil that affects us, there is, as it were, an untouched core: our identity as children of God. Each of us is a being who is soiled with sin, in urgent need of purification and conversion. And yet there is something within each of us that is absolutely pure and intact: the love that God has for us personally, as our Creator and Father. This is the whole basis of our identity, the inalienable fact that each is a beloved child of God. Reaching this point by means of faith is precisely what opens up and guarantees the possibility of the path of conversion and purification, which we cannot afford not to find.

All men and all women are in search of their identity, their personality at the deepest level. "Who am I?" Sometimes we ask ourselves that question in anguish halfway through our lives. We have tried to construct a personality for ourselves, to fulfill ourselves, following our personal aspirations and also in line with the criteria of success offered by the cultural context we live in. We have put ourselves into our work, family,

relationships, all sorts of responsibilities, and so on, sometimes to the point of exhaustion… . And yet a part of us is still empty, unsatisfied, perplexed: Who am I really? Does what I have lived through up till now really express what I am?

There is a whole aspect of our identity derived from our history, heredity, what we have experienced and the decisions we have made, but that is not the deepest part of ourselves. That deepest part comes to light only in the encounter with God, which strips us of everything artificial in our identity to bring us to what we really are, at the heart of our personhood. Our true identity is not so much a reality to be constructed as a gift to be received. It is not about achieving, but letting ourselves be begotten. “You are my son, today I have begotten you” (Ps 2:7); and “You are my beloved son” (Lk 3:22). In St. Luke’s Gospel, these last words are said by God the Father to Jesus at his baptism in the Jordan, but we can make them fully our own by virtue of our own baptism.

The essence of our personality consists of two realities that we are called to discover progressively. Simple, but containing inexhaustible richness, they are the unique love that God has for each of us, individually, and the unique love we can have for him.

Prayer and the meeting with God make us discover God’s unique love for us. It is a deep aspiration of every man (and, still more, every woman!) to feel uniquely loved. Not loved in a general way, as one of a large group, but appreciated in our uniqueness. The experience of being in love is so fascinating because it gives a glimpse of that: someone takes on, for us, a value that nobody else has, and we in our turn have a unique worth in their eyes.

This is what the Father’s love brings about. Each of us can experience that in his eyes we are loved, chosen by God, in an extremely personal way. We often have the feeling that God loves in a general way: he loves all men, I’m one of them, so he must take a bit of interest in me. But being loved in a “global” way, as one item in a collection, cannot satisfy us. And it is absolutely different from the reality of the particular, unique love that God the Father has for each of his children. God’s love is personal and individual. Each of us has every right to say: “God loves me as he loves nobody else in the world!” God does not love two people in the same way because it is actually his love that creates our personality, a different personality for each. There is a much greater difference between people’s

souls than between their faces, says St. Teresa of Avila. This unique personality is symbolized by the “new name” that Scripture speaks of. We read in the book of Isaiah:

> You shall be called by a new name which the mouth of the Lord will give (Is 62:2).

And in the book of the Apocalypse:

> He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To him who conquers I will give some of the hidden manna, and I will give him a white stone, with a new name written on the stone which no one knows except him who receives it (Rev 2:17).

God’s unique love for each of us includes the gift of a unique response in return. From many of the saints, and especially the women saints, we hear things like this: “Jesus, I want to love you as no one has ever loved you yet! I’d like to do crazier things for you than anyone has ever done before!”

Thinking of words like these, realizing that we will never outdo all those who have gone before us in love, we feel how poor we are. Yet such desires are not in vain but can be fulfilled in every individual’s life. Even though we are not Teresa of Avila or Francis of Assisi, we can give God (and also give our brothers and sisters, the Church, and the world) a love that nobody has ever yet given them. We can give them the love that belongs to us, in accordance with our own personality, in response to the love that God has for us and with the grace we receive from him. In God’s heart, in the mystery of the Church, each of us has a unique place, a unique and irreplaceable role, a fruitfulness that is all our own and cannot be taken on by anyone else.

Receiving this double certainty as the fruit of prayer—the certainty of being uniquely loved and the certainty of being able (in spite of our weakness and limitations) to love uniquely—is a very precious gift indeed. It is this that constitutes the deepest, most solid core of our identity.

Of course, this reality remains a mystery that cannot be fully grasped and cannot be properly put into words. It is not something one can claim as one’s own or claim the glory for; it is to be lived out in great humility and poverty. It is the object of faith and hope rather than a possession that one could take pride in. However, it is real enough and sure enough to give us the inner freedom and security we need to face life confidently.

Because of what we have just said, and for many other reasons besides, the discovery of God as Father, which is the essential fruit of fidelity to

prayer, is the most precious thing in the world, the greatest of all the gifts of the Spirit.

> For you did not receive the spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received the spirit of sonship. When we cry, “Abba! Father!” it is the Spirit himself bearing witness with our spirit that we are children of God (Rom 8:15–16).

God’s fatherhood in regard to us is the deepest reality there is, the richest and most inexpressible, an inconceivable abyss of life and mercy. There is no greater source of happiness than being a son or daughter, living in the movement of this fatherhood, receiving oneself and receiving everything from God’s goodness and generosity; confidently expecting everything, at every moment of our lives, from God’s gift. “How sweet it is to call God our father,” said Thérèse of Lisieux, shedding tears of happiness.[9]

6. Compassion for our neighbor is born of prayer

One of the most beautiful fruits of prayer (and a way of discerning whether prayer is genuine) is that it makes our love for our neighbor grow.

If our prayer is real (we will see what this means later on), it brings us closer to God, unites us to him, and makes us see and share the infinite love he has for everyone he has created. Prayer enlarges and softens our hearts. Where prayer is lacking, people’s hearts harden and love grows cold. Much could be said on this subject, and many testimonies quoted. I will content myself with a beautiful text from St. John of the Cross, a master of mysticism but also (contrary to the image one sometimes has of him) one of the most tender and compassionate men the world has ever known.

> It is an evident truth that the more people’s souls are united to God by love, the greater grows their compassion for their neighbor; for the more they love, the more they desire this same God to be loved and honored by everyone. And the more they desire this, the more they work for it, both in prayer and by all the other necessary means that they can.
>
> And in those who are thus possessed by God, the fervor and force of their charity are such that they cannot narrow their desires or content themselves with their own profit alone; but rather, as it seems little to them to go to heaven alone, they seek with anguish, with heavenly love and exquisite diligence, to take a great number of souls to heaven with them. And this is born of the great love they have for their God; that is the fruit and the proper effect of perfect prayer and contemplation.[10]

7. Prayer, a path of freedom

Faithfulness to prayer is a path of freedom. It teaches us progressively to seek in God the essential gifts we desire: infinite, everlasting love, peace, security, happiness … and to find them, because "he who seeks, finds," as the Gospel assures us (Mt 7:8).

If we do not learn to receive these much-needed gifts from God's hands, there is a serious risk that we will go and look for them elsewhere, expecting from the things of this world (money, work, relationships) what they are incapable of giving us.

Our relationships with our neighbors, other people, often disappoint us because, sometimes without realizing it, we expect from them things they cannot provide. From such close relationships we expect absolute happiness, total gratitude, perfect security. No created reality, no human being, no activity can fully satisfy such expectations. As we expect too much and do not get it, we become bitter, disappointed, and end by feeling terrible resentment against those who failed to live up to our expectations. It is not their fault; it was our expectation that was unreasonable. We wanted to obtain from another human being what God alone can truly give.

In saying this, I do not mean to dismiss interpersonal relationships or the diverse range of human activities. I have a strong belief in love, friendship, fraternity, everything we can receive from one another in our mutual dealings. The encounter with another person and the links forged with him or her can sometimes be a magnificent gift from God. God sometimes takes pleasure in showing us his love through the friendship or care of a person he places on our path. But we have to keep God at the center, and must not demand that a poor, limited, imperfect human being provide us with what God alone can really give.

Nor do I mean to claim that the gifts I spoke of earlier (peace, happiness, security, etc.) are granted to us as soon as we start to pray. Still, it is true that faithfulness to prayer is a concrete way of expressing the fact that we look to God to give us these things, in a movement of hope and faith, and what we hope for and expect from his mercy will be granted to us little by little. Here is a fundamental principle that helps establish balance in human relations and keeps us from demanding of others something they cannot give us, with all the sometimes traumatic consequences that can result.

The more God is at the center of our lives, and the more we expect everything from him and him alone, the better chance our human relationships will have of being well-balanced and happy.

To expect from any other reality what God alone can grant us has a name in the biblical tradition: idolatry. Without realizing it, we can commit idolatry in relation to many things: people, a job, passing an examination, the exercise of certain skills, some form of success, love, pleasure, etc. These are all good things in themselves, but on the condition that we not ask of them more than is right. Idolatry always makes us lose part of our freedom. Idols disappoint; we often end up by hating what we once adored. God himself will never disappoint us. He will lead us along unexpected and perhaps painful paths, but he will fulfill all our expectations. “In God alone is my soul at rest” (Ps 62:1, Grail).

Experience teaches us this. Faithfulness to prayer, even if it passes through difficult stages, times of dryness and trial, leads us progressively to find in God the deep peace, security, and happiness, that make us free in relation to other people. If we find our happiness and our peace in God, we will be able to give much to our neighbors, while also accepting all as they are, without holding it against them when they fall short of our expectations. God is enough.

I should add that the experience of finding happiness in prayer, even a certain pleasure, makes us freer in regard to that anxious search for human satisfactions that is a permanent temptation for us. Our world is suffering from a great spiritual emptiness, and it is striking how this inner void drives people into a frenzied search for sense satisfactions. I have nothing against life’s legitimate pleasures—a good meal, a bottle of Bordeaux, a relaxing bath. These are gifts from God, but it is preferable to take them in moderation. People sometimes have an insatiable need to feel, to savor, to experience newer and more intense emotions and sensations, and this need can lead to destructive behaviors, as in the areas of sex, drugs, etc. The pursuit of ever stronger sensations often ends by unleashing violence.

When meaning is lacking, people try to replace it with feelings and sensations. “Get your fill of sensations,” said a recent car advertisement. But that is a dead end, producing nothing but frustration, even self-destruction and violence. A thousand satisfactions do not add up to happiness.

One final remark on this matter of prayer as a path of freedom. As I shall explain later, faithfulness to prayer causes us little by little to experience that our real treasure is within us, that we possess within ourselves the Kingdom and its happiness. This discovery will make us freer with regard

to earthly possessions, liberating us gradually from the excessive need to have things—that current tendency to fill our lives with a host of material possessions that in the end weigh us down and harden our hearts.

8. Prayer unifies our lives

With time and fidelity, prayer is revealed as a wonderful "unifier" of our lives. When in our encounter with God we trustingly place in his fatherly hands everything that makes up our daily lives, with all their different events and circumstances, everything little by little becomes "digested," as it were—integrated, cleared of chaos, disarray, and incoherence. Then our lives find their own deep unity. God is One, and it is he who unifies our hearts, our personalities, our whole lives.

Psalm 86 makes this beautiful request: "Unite my heart to fear thy name" (v. 11). Thanks to our regular encounter with God in prayer, everything ultimately becomes positive: our desires, our good will, our efforts, but also our poverty, errors, and sins. Situations that make us happy or sad, good or bad choices, everything is "summed up" in Christ and becomes grace. Everything makes sense and becomes part of a path of growth in love. "Love is so powerful in works that it is able to bring profit out of everything, out of the good and the evil it finds in me," says St. Thérèse of Lisieux,[11] quoting St. John of the Cross.

In the story of the childhood of Jesus, St. Luke's Gospel says of our Lady: "Mary kept all these things, pondering them in her heart," (Lk 2:19) and "his mother kept all these things in her heart" (Lk 2:51). Everything Mary lived through—the graces she received, the words she heard, the events she experienced, whether filled with light, painful, or incomprehensible—were preserved by her in her heart and in her prayer. And so everything came to make sense, not through a process of intellectual analysis but through her inner prayer. She did not ruminate on things in her head, but kept them in her trusting, praying heart, where everything ultimately found its right place, having been unified and simplified.

Without faithfulness to our appointments with prayer, by contrast, there is a serious risk that our lives may never acquire any coherent meaning. "He who does not gather with me scatters," our Lord tells us (Mt 12:30; Lk 11:23).

1. *Novo Millennio Ineunte*, no. 32.

2. *Poems*, 17.

3. Maxim 110 (or 169), *Sayings of Light and Love*.

4. A Dominican religious (1903–1980) who was favored with great graces of mysticism, but who suffered from deep, serious depression before recovering her balance and peace of mind, and ended her days as a hermit. See Christiane Sanson, *Marie de la Trinité, de l'angoisse à la paix* (Paris: Cerf, 2005).

5. Marie de la Trinité, *Entre dans ma Gloire* (Paris: Arfuyen, 2003), 74.

6. Quoted by E. Renault, *Ste Thérèse d'Avila et l'expérience mystique* (Paris: Seuil, 1970), (Spiritual Masters series), 126.

7. *The Interior Castle*, "The Fifth Mansions," chapter 1.

8. Maxim 6 (or 1), *Sayings of Light and Love*.

9. Recorded by her sister Celine in: *Conseils et souvenirs, recueillis par Soeur Geneviève de la Sainte-Face, soeur et novice de sainte Thérèse de l'Enfant-Jésus* (Paris: Cerf, 1979).

10. John of the Cross, *Dictamenes de espíritu*, collected by Padre Eliseo de los Martires.

11. Manuscript A, 83 recto.

CHAPTER II

Conditions for Prayer to be Fruitful

I chose you and appointed you that
you should go and bear fruit
and that your fruit should abide.

— JOHN 15:16

In this second chapter I propose to answer the following question: What will enable our prayer life to bring about a real encounter with God and produce abundant, lasting fruit as a result?

In the prologue to his book *The Ascent of Mount Carmel*, St. John of the Cross says something quite astonishing:

There are many souls who think they do not have prayer, yet they have much; and, on the contrary, others who think they have much prayer but have very little.

In other words, there are people who think they pray badly but actually pray very well, while others imagine they pray well, but pray badly!

How can we tell the difference? What are the criteria?

It is not easy to discern, to judge the quality of someone's prayer life. Especially not our own! Nevertheless, I shall venture to say something on this delicate topic, because the question is important.

To evaluate our life of prayer, we can take two different starting points: its fruits and the way we set about praying. I take them in turn.

1. Prayer as a place to find inner peace

"The tree is known by its fruit," says our Lord in the Gospel (Mt 12:33). If our prayer is genuine, it will bear fruit: it will make us humbler, gentler, more patient, more trusting, etc. It will bring all the "fruits of the Spirit" little by little to flower in our lives. St. Paul gives a list in the Letter to the Galatians: "love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentle ness, self-control …" (Gal 5:22–23).

Above all, genuine prayer will make us love God and our neighbor more. Charity is the fruit and the ultimate criterion of every prayer life. “If I have not love, I am nothing,” asserts St. Paul forcefully (1 Cor 13:1–3).

Without wishing to deny the absolute priority of this criterion (though I would ask: is it possible to measure the degree of our love?), I believe that for practical purposes we won’t go wrong if we take peace as the criterion.

People’s prayer lives can be said to be basically “on track” if they experience them as a place of quiet, a place where they find peace. They can say:

> My prayer isn’t wonderful, I’m far from being one of the great mystics, I often have distractions and times of dryness; most of the time I don’t feel very much, and I certainly don’t claim to have reached the pinnacle of the spiritual life. Despite that, I recognize that for me, the fact of keeping these regular appointments with our Lord is producing an effect of inner pacification. This peace is not something I always feel with the same intensity, but it is often the result of my times of prayer.
>
> These times of prayer enable me to be more tranquil, more confident, to stand back from my problems and worries, and not be so traumatized by the difficulties that weigh me down … And I feel that this peacefulness, this objectivity about my worries, is not the fruit of my reflections or any psychological efforts I may make, but comes as a gift, a grace. Sometimes it comes quite unexpectedly: I might have every reason to be stressed, and suddenly my heart receives a sense of tranquility that I know very well is not produced by myself. It comes from Someone else… .

If we think carefully about this, we see that it could not be otherwise: God is an ocean, an abyss of peace. If our prayer is sincere and really brings us into communion with him, part of that divine peace cannot fail to be transmitted to us. “Prayer makes us the gift, every day, of a totally new peace,” says Father Matta El Maskine, who brought about the current monastic renewal among the Copts in Egypt.[1]

In God there is an intensity of life whose power we cannot begin to measure: “The Lord your God is a devouring fire” (Dt 4:24). And at the same time, there is in God a gentleness and peace of infinite depth, which is at least in part bestowed upon our hearts when we hold ourselves in humble openness to his presence. “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest” (Mt 11:28); “the peace of God, which passes all understanding, will keep your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus” (Phil 4:7).

This gift of inner peace is a precious one, because in this aura of peace love can grow. This peace makes us ready for the work of grace and facilitates our discernment of situations and decisions that need to be taken. Obviously it is not always experienced in the same way; it is normal for us

to have ups and downs in this area, to go through times of trial in which we find ourselves filled with worry and cannot easily rid ourselves of it.

But my statement remains true: if, taken altogether, in the long term, we experience our prayer life as a habitual source of inner peace, it is a very good sign.

On the other hand, in the absence of that experience we should ask ourselves some questions. This is a sign that we are not praying enough or that our inner dispositions are not what they should be. In such cases it seems to me necessary that we open our hearts to a spiritual companion or guide.

I would add in conclusion that one of the most valuable fruits of prayer is purity of heart. Prayer contains a great power of inner purification. In prayer, the heart is calmed, simplified, and redirected toward God. What is a pure heart, if not a heart entirely turned toward God, in the trusting desire to love him truly and do his whole will?

2. The dispositions that make prayer fruitful

Now let us tackle the question of discerning the genuineness of our prayer from a different angle: not the fruits it brings, but the way we set about praying.

A first point (which follows from what I am going to say later, but it is good to emphasize it) is that fidelity should be a principle quality of prayer. Jesus does not ask us to pray well; he asks us to pray without ceasing!

Faithfulness (if, of course, it is not just routine, but is motivated by a sincere desire to find God, please him, and love him) will produce all the rest. The main battle in the prayer life is perseverance. As St. Teresa of Avila notes, the devil does all he can to get souls away from faithfulness to prayer, using every possible or imaginable excuse: it’s pointless, you’re not worthy to pray, you’re wasting your time, you’ll pray better if you put it off till tomorrow, there’s this urgent thing you really must do now, it would be a shame to miss that fantastic TV program, what are people going to think of you, etc. St. Teresa explains that it is natural for the devil to put up a stiff fight on this point, for someone faithful to prayer is quite certainly lost to him. That person may still fall often, but after each fall he or she will have the grace to rise up again even higher than before.

In order to gain his end, the devil is quite right to use no half-measures on this point! Deceiver that he is, he knows that the souls who persevere in prayer are lost to him, that all the falls he brings about only help them, with God's grace, to spring up again much higher than before and serve our Lord better: hence his determination on this point.[2]

She invites us, therefore, to persevere in prayer,

no matter what happens or could happen, whatever the difficulties or nay-sayers, whether we reach our goal or perish on the way, whether we lack the courage to tackle the trials of the journey or the world collapses around us![3]

3. Prayer vivified by faith, hope, and love

The idea I am going to develop now is simple but very important, and it can provide us with some valuable markers on our personal journey, especially in dealing with the difficulties we meet in our prayer life. It is this: our prayer will be good and fruitful if it is based on faith, hope, and love. It should be supported by the exercise of the three "theological virtues," as they are classically called,[4] which are given so much importance in Scripture (particularly in the teachings of St. Paul), because it is they that drive all Christian life.[5]

Having decided to dedicate time to personal prayer, we can set about it in all sorts of different ways: meditate on a passage from Scripture; recite a psalm slowly; converse freely with our Lord; let our heart sing; say our Rosary or use some other form of repetitive prayer; just be there in front of our Lord without saying anything, in an attitude of simple availability or adoration; and so on. We will return to these different possibilities later on; we are free to use them according to what suits us best at a given point.

What matters, however, is not what particular method we use, but to ascertain the basic dispositions of our heart when we pray. It is these inner dispositions, not a technique or particular form of prayer, that guarantee the fruitfulness of our prayer life.

What matters ultimately is that when we start to pray, when we use this or that method in order to pray, we base everything on inner dispositions of faith, hope, and love.

Let us look in detail at each of these three "theological virtues," their importance, and their role in our prayer.

4. The gateway of faith

Prayer is essentially an act of faith. It is even the first and most natural way to express our faith. If someone said, “I believe in God, but I don’t pray,” you could reasonably ask that person, “What God do you believe in? If the God you believe in is the God of the Bible, the living God, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, the God with whom Jesus spent his nights in prayer, calling him ‘Abba!’—how could you possibly not feel the slightest desire to talk to him?”

Faith is expressed, renewed, purified, and strengthened when exercised in prayer. Even if we do not realize it (like Monsieur Jourdain in Molière’s comedy *Le Bourgeois Gentilhomme*, who had been speaking prose all his life without realizing it), as soon as we start to pray we are making an act of faith: that God exists, that it is worthwhile speaking to him and listening for what he will say, that he loves us, that it is a good thing to spend some of our time with him, etc. Every prayer contains an act of faith that is implicit but absolutely fundamental.

It is very encouraging to understand that it is this act of faith that unites us to God. “The more faith a soul has, the more he or she is united to God,” says St. John of the Cross.[6] What brings about union with God is not feelings or thought processes, but faith. Let’s look at why that is so.

5. The role of emotions in our prayer life

The human capacity to feel, to have emotions, is a very valuable faculty, and there is no question of discounting it. Being able to feel, react, be moved, be stirred interiorly is an essential part of being human. I would even say that in the spiritual life it is absolutely indispensable that our feelings and emotions play their parts. If we have never actually *tasted* God’s presence and tenderness, he remains a stranger for us, far off, an abstraction, purely an idea.

Too often in the recent life of the Church, believers have suffered from a failure to give its due place to their capacity to feel. One of the Psalms invites us: “Taste and see that the Lord is good” (Ps 34:8). We have the right to ask for sense-perceptible graces, so that we can taste something of the mystery of God, the truths of the faith, with our bodies, senses, and emotions. Otherwise we will not be able to understand them and bring them into our lives in a dynamic way. All the methods of prayer and meditation that bring the senses into play, and call on our human ability to be moved,

are perfectly legitimate. I think churches have emptied in the Western world partly because of celebrations that are too cold and verbose, incapable of awakening any emotion other than boredom. There is a lot to be done so that in the Church's life, and especially in the liturgy, there is beauty and genuinely felt fervor that can touch people's hearts.

That said, we also need to recognize the limits of feelings. It is indispensable to "taste God," but *what we taste of God is not yet God*. God is infinitely greater, infinitely beyond everything we can apprehend through our feelings. And the pursuit of feelings can become an end in itself. It may lead to greed, attachment, and lack of freedom. Our capacity for feelings needs to undergo purification. Prayer is about meeting God, not just about the feelings that God's presence gives us. Therefore, we need to accept that sometimes we will feel empty, dry, and arid. And at such times we have to remember that what matters is not what we feel, but what we believe. The act of faith goes far beyond our emotions, and really makes us encounter God even when we are most totally devoid of feeling, our hearts as dry as the Sahara desert, without the slightest drop of fervor.

One other thought, related to what was said above about prayer as a path of freedom. Remaining faithful to prayer in spite of aridity, exercising faith in prayer, sets us progressively free with regard to our feelings. Then we are able to bring our feelings and emotions fully into play, and even to awaken faculties that have remained dormant up until now, to make new emotions vibrate in our hearts ("chords of music that had dwelt in oblivion up to this point," as St. Thérèse of Lisieux calls them[7]), but without becoming enslaved to them, or dependent on them. Our modern culture presses people to let themselves be ruled by their feelings alone, and that leads to all kinds of immaturity and even enslavement. When, for example, our relationships with others are based only on the pleasure they give us, those relationships are merely childish. True freedom consists of loving others, whether they please us or not; faithfulness to prayer, no matter what the cost, is valuable training in this sense.

6. The role and limits of the mind

Much the same can be said about our intellects. Reason has a fundamental role in human life and spiritual life; faith cannot do without reason. We should do all we can to understand with our intelligence what we believe,

since our minds need to assimilate the content of the faith. That is what theology is for. The more we understand what we believe, the more our faith will be light and strength for us. Additionally, in our prayer life we will often receive lights that enlighten our intelligences in many areas: an understanding of certain aspects of the mystery of God, a more vivid perception of the person of Christ, or the meaning of human destiny, etc. We will sometimes receive wonderful, valuable lights on the meaning of a particular phrase or passage of Scripture. Besides these general lights on the content of the faith, our minds will also receive more specific enlightenment regarding our own lives: what choice to make, how to rule our lives in given circumstances, what advice to give someone who asks for it, etc.

Each time the intelligence, the mind, is enlightened in this way, it is a precious gift, and we need to do all we can to live out our faith in an intelligent way, employing the faculties of reflection, comprehension, analysis, and the rest. We should ask for and seek the lights that enlighten intelligence. Indeed, we cannot do without them. A lazy mind and spiritual vitality do not go together.

That said, we need also to realize that the intelligence has its limitations. It is good to understand truths about God, but we should bear in mind that *everything we understand about God is still not God*. God is infinitely beyond all that our minds can image or grasp. No concept of God truly corresponds to what God is.

> O the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways![8]

The intellect can bring us nearer to God, but it does not give us access to what God truly is in himself. Only faith can do that. At certain points in Christian life, our minds must fall silent and admit their powerlessness. The greatest theologian in the history of the Church, St. Thomas Aquinas, recognized at the end of his life that everything he had written was only straw.

It is normal, then, and even necessary, that on our path as Christians, and especially in our prayer lives, the intelligence should sometimes find itself in a certain degree of darkness. Regarding questions relating to faith, the mystery of God, or even the meaning of this or that world event or personal experience the mind sometimes is simply lost for an answer. That is

disquieting since not understanding always produces a painful sense of frustration. But it is inevitable. Then it is helpful to recall that not our intelligence but faith gives us access to God and the deep truth of our own lives, and that should be enough for us even if our intelligence is in its death throes.

These times of darkness are necessary for the mind to purify and refine it. The fact is that many things are often at work in our use of our minds, in our desire to understand, from which we need deliverance: some curiosity, a lot of pride, conceit, and desire for power (to understand is to dominate); as well as a human quest for security (to understand is to master and control).

To know everything, we must first pass through a stage of not knowing … we cannot truly grow, humanly or spiritually, without going through times when the intelligence is painfully humbled.

We should also recognize that thinking and reflecting can bring us nearer to God, they can be a path toward him, but they cannot give us God himself. Thinking of an object means holding it at a certain distance in order to master it. That is not possible with God—we cannot "think about" God in the sense of making him into an object. It is faith, love, and adoration that place us in contact with God. The spiritual life has sometimes been over-intellectualized in the Western world.

The conclusion to which what has just been said obviously points to this: our emotions and our intellects are useful and valuable, but they cannot serve as the basis for our relationship with God or our prayer life. The only basis for that has to be faith. When our emotions are dry and our minds are blind, faith should be enough to carry us forward. Faith is free, untrammeled. It can feed on what stirs our emotions and enlightens our minds, but it can also do without those things.

Ultimately, these considerations have one practical consequence, and it is an extremely consoling one. There are moments in our prayer lives when we are, quite simply, poor. Despite our good will and efforts, we remain arid, cold, devoid of feeling, understanding, and lights… . At such times we tend to be discouraged and think we must be very far from God. We envy those who express delicate emotions and deep thoughts, we feel we are totally helpless, compared with what the lives of saints tell us about their fervor

and mystical graces. We see ourselves as distant from God since we have neither any fervor nor any light about him.

If that happens to you, my dear reader, then remember what I have said: It does not matter what you feel or don't feel, what you understand or can't understand. If your feelings or your intelligence do not give God to you, faith will. It is enough to make a humble, sincere act of faith for you to be in contact with God from that moment, with absolute certainty. Faith, and faith alone, establishes real contact with the living presence of God. When everything else is lacking, faith is sufficient. If we go courageously in that direction, we will end by experiencing how true it is, and how what we grasp by the act of faith is really given to us. "Be it done for you as you have believed," Jesus says constantly in the Gospel.

In this necessary experience of passing through trials, the role of emotions and intelligence should not be denied or suppressed, but they need to be assigned the right place. The painful times of "crisis" for human faculties during the spiritual journey are not intended to destroy them, but to purify and refine them, so that, when used, they are no longer a hindrance to union with God. They need to pass through darkness in order to grow accustomed to a new, deeper perception of God and his wisdom. They must be impoverished to be enriched.

7. Touching God

An interesting analogy might be drawn between the role of faith in the spiritual life and the sense of touch in the sense life. Touch is the first of our five senses to develop (while still in our mother's womb), and it is at the origin of all the others. It does not have the richness of sight (with the diversity of images and colors) or hearing (with the variety of sounds, tones, and melodies). But touch is the most primordial sense and the one most essential to life and communication. And, above all, it has one advantage that the other senses don't have: reciprocity, meaning that we cannot touch an object without being touched by it. (We can see without being seen by something or hear without being heard.) The contact created by touch is more intimate and direct than the contact produced by the other senses. Touch is the sense of communion par excellence.

Analogously, faith is characterized by a kind of poverty (believing is not necessarily seeing, or understanding, or feeling), but faith is the most vital

thing in the spiritual life. In a mysterious but real way, by faith we can "touch God" and let ourselves be touched by him, set up an inner communion with him and allow ourselves to be transformed little by little by his grace.

Faith practiced in prayer gives us a knowledge of God that remains obscure, mysterious, and surpasses all understanding. Faith does not satisfy all our human curiosity. It does, of course, give a meaning to everything in life, but it does not necessarily answer all our questions. Paradoxically, however, the knowledge faith gives us of God is much more able to fire us with love than any clear, distinct intellectual knowledge could do. St. John of the Cross uses this beautiful expression: "the faith in which we love God without comprehending him."[9]

8. The faith that opens all doors

Faith has something marvelous about it, and we do not sufficiently appreciate its importance and power. It is a humble and often hidden thing: a secret disposition of the heart and will, a simple adherence to God's word and promises, in an attitude of submission and trust. At the same time, it is this humble act, and it alone, that little by little gives us access to all the riches of the mystery of God. We can understand why Jesus insists so much in the Gospel upon the importance and power of faith. All our deficiencies are in some way the result of a lack of faith, and there is nothing more urgent or more fruitful than to increase our faith.

To complete the treatment of this subject, here is a lovely passage by St. Louis-Marie Grunion de Monfort. In his *Treatise on True Devotion to the Virgin Mary*, he proposes consecration to Mary as an effective path to holiness, basing this proposition on the idea that if we give ourselves entirely to Mary, she will give herself entirely to us[10] and will make us share in the graces she has received from the Almighty, especially her faith. The Second Vatican Council, as is well known, particularly highlighted Mary's faith. Describing the faith we will come to share in, thanks to our Lady's motherly care of us, as a mysterious passkey that opens all doors, St. Louis-Marie says this:

> Mary will share her faith with you. Her faith on earth was stronger than that of all the patriarchs, prophets, apostles and saints… . It will cause you to depend less upon sense-perceptible and extra ordinary feelings. For it is a lively faith animated by love enabling you to do everything from no

other motive than that of pure love. It is a firm faith, unshakable as a rock, prompting you to remain firm and steadfast in the midst of storms and tempests. It is an active and probing faith which like some mysterious passkey admits you into the mysteries of Jesus Christ and of man's final destiny and into the very heart of God himself. It is a courageous faith which inspires you to undertake and carry out without hesitation great things for God and the salvation of souls. This faith will be your flaming torch, your very life with God, your secret fund of divine Wisdom, and an all-powerful weapon for you to enlighten those who sit in darkness and the shadow of death. It inflames those who are lukewarm and need the gold of fervent love. It restores life to those who are dead through sin. It moves and transforms hearts of marble and cedars of Lebanon by gentle and convincing argument. Finally, this faith will strengthen you to resist the devil and the other enemies of salvation.[11]

9. Prayer and hope

Having spoken about faith as the basis of prayer, we now look at the equally essential role of hope.

Prayer is an act of hope: it means recognizing that we need God, can't manage by ourselves when faced with all life's challenges, rely on God more than on our own resources and talents, and trust him to give us what we need. In prayer our hope is expressed and, in consequence, deepened and strengthened. This line of thought necessarily leads us to humility and spiritual poverty, which cannot be separated from the virtue of hope.

The act of hope consists, fundamentally, of the following attitude: "I recognize that I am small and poor before God, but I confidently expect everything from him. And therefore my poverty is not a problem but a stroke of luck."

Our prayer lives lead us necessarily to experience our own poverty. Sometimes this is very painful, but we should not be afraid of this experience because ultimately it is extremely beneficial.

Let's start from our own lives. That half hour or hour spent in personal, silent prayer, perhaps in a corner of our room or in a church, is sometimes a time of great beauty and sweetness. We taste a happiness, joy, and peace more precious than anything this world can offer.

But things are not always like that. This time of prayer can be difficult. Sometimes, from the very fact that we are alone, in silence, having gotten away from our habitual occupations, we find ourselves face-to- face with all that is not going well in our lives. Our failings, our falls and mistakes, the difficulty we have in being recollected, our remorse for the past, our worries about the future, etc.,—the list could be very long—all come to the surface. Far from experiencing the time of prayer as something positive, we

experience it instead as a time when we painfully confront everything that seems negative in our lives. That could lead to discouragement, to the temptation to abandon prayer and turn to more pleasant occupations or more enjoyable distractions. Indeed, many people renounce prayer, and avoid all solitude and silence, because they fear that inescapable confrontation with themselves which prayer obliges them to undergo.

We should not be scared of this experience. It is normal, and even absolutely necessary. Jesus one day said to St. Louis, King of France, “You would like to pray like a saint, but I am inviting you to pray like a poor man!”

Prayer brings us inexorably face-to-face with what we really are. Every single person has his or her dark side, that part of themselves that sometimes weighs heavily and is a source of shame, guilt, and anguish: human limitations, psychological weaknesses, emotional wounds, areas of complicity with evil, incapacities, falls of different kinds, etc. Prayer makes us enter more and more deeply into God’s light, and like a ray of sunlight coming into a dark room and revealing the tiniest speck of dust floating in the air, that lays bare our imperfections and sins.

Of course, it is not only prayer that makes us experience our poverty; the whole of life and its difficult situations involve experiencing our limitations, weaknesses, wounds, and sins. But prayer intensifies the awareness of all that and obliges one to face up to it without any possible escape route.

What should we do then? Above all, do not panic. “Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick; I came not to call the righteous, but sinners,” Jesus says (Mk 2:17).

Salvation lies in a double attitude: humility and hope. We need to consent fully to what we are, accept the cruel revelation of our limitations and faults, and profit from it all by learning no longer to put all our trust and hope in our qualities and good deeds, but in God alone.

“Everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but he who humbles himself will be exalted” (Lk 14:11). With these words the Gospel invites us to recognize and accept our wretchedness fully, however deeprooted and troubling it is, and throw ourselves into God’s arms with blind trust in his mercy and power. We need to accept ourselves as radically poor and transform that poverty into a cry, an expectation, and an unconquerable hope. Then God will come to our help. “This poor man cried, and the Lord

heard him, and saved him out of all his troubles" (Ps 34:6). "For he has not despised or abhorred the affliction of the afflicted; and he has not hid his face from him, but has heard, when he cried to him" (Ps 22:24).

The only prayer God hears is the prayer of the poor man. Not that of the Pharisee who, satisfied with himself and his good deeds, thanks God that he is better than others, but that of the tax-collector who stands far off and beats his breast, saying, "God, be merciful to me, a sinner!" (Lk 18:13). The prayer that pierces heaven, touches God's heart, and draws down his grace, is the prayer that springs up from the depths of our wretchedness and sin. "Out of the depths I cry to thee, O Lord! Lord, hear my voice!" (Ps 130:1–2).

10. The power of humility

The painful experience of our radical poverty should impel us toward humility and hope, which are basically inseparable. Humility means recognizing that everything we are and have is a totally gratuitous gift from God's love, and that we can attribute absolutely nothing to ourselves. "What have you that you did not receive?" asks St. Paul (1 Cor 4:7). Humility also means consenting peacefully to our limitations and weaknesses—"loving one's littleness and poverty," as St. Thérèse of Lisieux put it.[12]

It is vital for us to understand the unheard-of power of humility and hope. St. Paul says, "Hope does not disappoint us" (Rom 5:5). St. John of the Cross states: "One obtains from God as much as one hopes for."[13] This is the most consoling idea of all: By hope, we can, quite certainly, obtain everything from God. Hope consists, amidst radical poverty, of expecting everything from God with full confidence. God will give us his gifts not according to our virtues, our qualities, our merits, or our good deeds, but *according to our hope*. The same applies to humility: "God opposes the proud, but gives grace to the humble" (1 Pt 5:5). "He adorns the humble with victory" (Ps 149:4). Humility has absolute power over God's heart, and attracts the fullness of his grace. When humility is joined with hope, it "compels" God, so to speak, to come down and take care of us.

If we could really measure the power of humility, we would consider that our greatest treasure is everything that obliges us to be humble—our failings, our incapacities, and our falls. "The more the soul is afflicted, stripped and deeply humiliated, the more it acquires, with purity, an

aptitude for the heights. The height that it becomes capable of [reaching] is measured by the depth of the abyss where it has its roots and foundations," says Angela of Foligno.[14] If we wish to rise very high, we must first go down very low! Teresa of Avila puts it like this: "I consider that the day when the humble revelation of ourselves has brought us many afflictions and sorrows, is a greater grace from God than many full days of prayer."[15] Elsewhere she says, "The whole edifice of prayer is founded on humility and the more a soul abases herself in prayer, the higher God raises her."[16]

I recently read some passages from a seventeenth-century French religious, Catherine de Bar, who founded ten monasteries of Benedictines of Perpetual Adoration of the Blessed Sacrament. She beautifully describes the power of humility to attract God's grace:

> We do not know or we do not want to know the secret of how to ravish God's heart. Abase yourself and despise yourself interiorly,[17] not in words, but in very truth. If you do what I tell you, all heaven will come and pour itself out into your soul and you will overflow with so many graces that you will have enough to convert the whole world. No-one can know or taste God except *humbly*.[18]
>
> One always wants to be something, and if it is not among creatures it is in God, and nothing in the world is so rare as to find a person who is content not to be anything at all so that God can be everything in them. Everything in God, and God for himself. That is my state and my one source of rejoicing, which nothing whatever can interrupt, not even my imperfections and sins. Expect nothing from yourself, but everything from our Lord Jesus Christ.[19]

St. Thérèse of Lisieux also explains how greatly humility attracts God's grace:

> Ah, let us then keep far away from everything that shines, let us love our littleness, let us love to feel nothing, and then we will be poor in spirit and Jesus will come to look for us, however far off we may be, and will transform us into flames of love.[20]

It is our lack of humility alone that prevents God from filling us with gifts as much as he would like and is able to do; because our lack of humility makes us attribute to ourselves what is really a free gift of God's mercy.

> God asks for nothing better than to fill us with himself and his graces, but he sees that we are so full of pride and self-satisfaction that it prevents him from communicating himself to us. For if our souls are not founded upon true humility and self-contempt, we are incapable of receiving God's gifts, because our self-love would devour them. So God is obliged to leave us in our poverty, darkness and sterility to make us realize our nothingness. That is how necessary the virtue of humility is.[21]

Humility cannot be manufactured to order, it can only come as the fruit of a painful confrontation with our inner poverty and weakness, a stripping

of all human conceit and all the claims of our ego.

> Humility does not consist of having humble thoughts, but of sustaining the weight of the truth, which is the abyss of our extreme wretchedness, when it pleases God to make us feel it.[22]

These words sound austere, but they contain a sweet and gentle mystery. One of the strangest and most beautiful experiences of the spiritual life is this: in the times when we feel crushed by our wretchedness, but recognize that we are wretched and consent to it fully, when we accept to "live in our nothingness," so to speak, and not try to escape (because it is the truth), then God visits us with tender consolation and we feel clearly that all the riches of his love and mercy belong to us. Our poverty makes us infinitely rich. "Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (Mt 5:3). Thérèse of Lisieux says that "no joy can compare with the joy tasted by those who are truly poor in spirit."[23]

To round off this subject, here are some beautiful words by a Carthusian (in an article about the prayer of the heart) on the deep and positive meaning of this experience of poverty and weakness which is an integral part of the spiritual life. It is the foundation of true love.

> Even in the natural order, all genuine love is a victory of weakness. Loving is not dominating or possessing, imposing oneself on the person loved. Loving means that one welcomes the other person without putting up any defenses. In return, one is certain of being welcomed totally by that person without being judged, condemned, or compared. There are no more trials of strength between two people who love each other. There is a sort of mutual inner intelligence, thanks to which one can no longer fear any danger whatever coming from the other person. This experience, even if it always remains imperfect, is already convincing. And yet it is only a reflection of the divine reality. From the moment we begin to believe truly, in our hearts, in God the Father's infinite tenderness, we feel in some way compelled to descend further and further into a positive, joyful acceptance of not-having, not-knowing, and not-being-able. This does not entail any unhealthy self-humiliation. We are simply entering into the world of love and trust.[24]

11. Going down into ourselves

Let me use an image to put everything I have just said in a slightly different way and express what we experience if we persevere in prayer, both as suffering and, at the same time, as happiness.

Someone who persists in praying day after day is like a man who acquires an old house in the country with a well in the garden. The well has not been used for maybe the last hundred years and is blocked up. The man thinks it would be a good idea to restore it to use, so he starts clearing it. To

begin with, it is not very pleasant: he finds dead leaves, stones, mud, and all sorts of rubbish, some of it quite disgusting. If he does not give up, but continues toiling away, in the end he discovers at the bottom of the well water that is clear, fresh, and unbelievably thirst-quenching.

That is how it is for us. Faithfulness to prayer involves a painful confrontation with what we have in our hearts. There we find things that weigh us down, tangled things, dirty things. But the day comes when, deeper down than our psychological wounds, even deeper than our sins and dirt, we reach a pure spring, the presence of God in the depths of our hearts, enabling our whole selves to be purified and renewed. “He who believes in me, out of his heart shall flow rivers of living water” (Jn 7:38). Human beings are not purified from the outside inwards, but starting from within. Not so much by a moral effort we make, but by discovering a Presence within us and letting him act freely.

By faithfulness to prayer we find within us a space of purity, peace, and freedom, God’s presence, closer to us than we are to ourselves. The center of the soul is God, says St. John of the Cross. We learn little by little to center our lives on him, and no longer on our wounded psychological periphery—our fears, bitterness, aggressiveness, jealousies, etc.

This kind of interiorization, which is one of the fruits of prayer, is much more than simply recollecting ourselves. It is discovering and uniting ourselves to an inner Presence that becomes our life and the source of all our thoughts and actions. I will come back to this point.

12. Prayer as an act of love

Having spoken about prayer as an act of faith and an act of hope, I want now to look at the third “theological virtue,” which is also a foundation for our prayer life: love.

Prayer is a privileged place for love to be exercised, and hence deepened and purified. It is a marvelously effective school of love. It is a school of patience, faithfulness, humility, and trust, and these attitudes are the most genuine expressions of true love. Prayer is a school of love of God, love of our neighbor and also (not least importantly) charity toward our own selves.

In seeking to situate love’s place in the prayer life one might say it is the goal of prayer and also that, together with faith and hope, it is the main means to prayer. That may seem like a paradox, but it applies to many

things in the dynamism of the spiritual life. The movements of the soul are circular, says Pseudo-Dionysius, a sixth-century Greek father.

St. Teresa of Avila insists on this point in her teachings on prayer. It is not a question of thinking a lot but of loving a lot. Just as well, she adds, because not all souls are gifted with imagination, but all are gifted with the power to love.

Prayer, then, is an act of love of God. Praying means accepting God's love trustingly. Praying is not first and foremost doing something for God, but primarily accepting his love, letting ourselves be loved by him. We find it hard to put this into practice, because we do not believe strongly enough in God's love; we often feel that we are unworthy of that love, and we are more centered on ourselves than on him. In our subtle pride, we want to do beautiful things for God instead of trying to find out what God wants to do for us gratuitously.

It is essential to hold ourselves in God's presence, poor and little as we are, but open and receptive to his Love. We need to give God permission to love us (if I may so put it), instead of wanting to do anything, no matter what it is, on our own initiative. The activity that really counts during our prayer is not ours but God's. We are asked to accept, and that is all! Teresa of Avila defined prayer as "a friendly interchange where we talk frequently and intimately with Him who we know loves us."[25] This definition highlights the fact that in the first place comes God's love for us, not our love for him. "Merit does not consist of doing or giving a lot, but rather of receiving and loving a lot," says St. Thérèse of Lisieux.[26]

St. Thérèse had the defect of often falling asleep during her prayer; it was not bad will, but a weakness due to her youth and lack of sleep. In a passage in her autobiography, she says:

> I really am far from being a saint, this alone is enough to prove it; instead of rejoicing at my dryness, I should attribute it to the smallness of my fervor and fidelity, and I ought to be miserable about going to sleep, as I have done for the past seven years, during my prayers and my thanksgiving. Well, I'm not miserable about it… . I think how small children please their parents just as much when they are asleep as when they are awake.[27]

In this passage, humorously, she shows clearly that loving God does not consist primarily in doing things for him (what could he possibly need?) but in the first place, of letting ourselves be loved by him, believing in his love for us. That is what gives him most pleasure. Nothing pleases him as much as his little children's trust.

It is true, of course, that prayer is also a response on our part to the love God has for us. Praying is giving him our time, and time is life! What is more, in prayer we offer ourselves to God, we give him our hearts and our lives, to belong to him completely we make ourselves available for whatever he wants, we tell him that we love him, we make resolutions about all these things, etc.

Prayer is also an act of love for our neighbors. When we intercede for them, the act of love is explicit and conscious. But even in a prayer of simple adoration, where our neighbors' needs do not occupy our thoughts, we are practicing real charity toward them. Prayer makes us gentler and more peaceful, humble and merciful, and the people whom God puts on our path undoubtedly benefit from it. I would add that the mere fact of turning toward God, approaching him in faith and love, means that all the people we carry in our hearts, and even those who, without our knowing it, are linked to us by the thousand invisible but real threads of the Communion of Saints, are also "automatically" brought closer to God and benefit from it. Let's listen to what St. Thérèse of Lisieux says on this subject:

> One morning in my thanksgiving, Jesus gave me a simple way of carrying out my mission. He made me understand these words from the Song of Songs: "Draw me: we will run after thee to the odour of thy ointments." (Song 1:4, DRB). O Jesus, it is not even necessary to say "By drawing me, draw the souls whom I love!" That simple word "Draw me" is enough. Lord, I understand: when a soul lets herself be captivated by the intoxicating odor of your ointments, she could never run after you alone, all the souls she loves are also drawn after her; it is done without constraint, without effort, it is a natural result of her being attracted toward you.[28]

We sometimes tend to think of prayer as a duty. We do not realize sufficiently how lucky we are to have the opportunity to pray. Prayer enables us to be united, truly, to each and every person in their needs and sufferings. That is a huge source of comfort, because the worst suffering in life (as parents, for instance, know very well) is not being able to help someone we love when they are in distress. Humanly, we are sometimes totally powerless and bereft of resources to help those we love. How lucky we are that we can then resort to prayer! What a gift from God!

Finally, prayer is an act of love for ourselves. Prayer brings us the greatest possible benefits. It brings us the most essential of gifts, God himself, and everything that we can find in him: trust and confidence, peace, light, strength, positive growth. As I said earlier, prayer is also a school of reconciliation with ourselves, of accepting our own weakness. It

leads us little by little to discover our real identity, the grace of being children of God. There is a wrong way of loving ourselves, which consists of selfishness, pride, and narcissism; but there is also a good and necessary way of loving ourselves and seeking our own good. Prayer is one of the primary sources of this right kind of love for oneself.

The subject is fundamental, but I shall not say any more here about prayer as the exercise of love and hence as a place for growth in love for God, our neighbor, and ourselves. Instead I conclude by quoting a letter from Sister Marie of the Trinity to one of her novices. It makes clear the primacy love should have over thought in our prayer life. It is good to repeat this, since we in the Western world tend toward a sort of intellectualism that confuses the spiritual life with mental activity. (Here I am jumping ahead somewhat to the subject of the next chapter, on methods of prayer.)

> The whole point, then, is to come to our Lord and it is above all by prayer that we do this; that we approach and dwell in Him who dwells in us.
>
> This morning, thinking of you, it seemed to me that it would be good for you to apply yourself above all to a prayer full of love, so that you concern yourself more with our Lord by the affection of your will than by meditating at length. Indeed, our mind is so mobile that the moment you think it is fixed in one place, off it goes, heaven only knows where! As for our love, it is completely different—when it is expressed, when it desires, when it seeks, it only has eyes for what it loves, and the more it looks at what it loves, the more it kindles and remains fixed there—turning aside from all else. The mind, to understand some subject, has to summon up many ideas, lines of argument, etc., but love works the other way round: it leaves everything for the sake of what it loves, and when it has found that, it remains totally immersed in it, giving itself and abandoning itself entirely, as though in one single act.
>
> Certainly, at the beginning of our prayer, we should give a light to our love: a mystery of faith, a promise of Jesus Christ, examples and virtues of the Son, the Beloved of the Father; but once our soul feels attentive to God, we can devote ourselves to loving him in accordance with what we see in him—and love will reveal new splendors to us.
>
> The prayer should be totally related to the love which is its whole perfection—it should have the effect of fixing us on God, not through the senses, but through the will; and turning us away from everything that saddens him about us, and making us apply ourselves to be more and more faithful, with more and more love, to his most holy and most lovable will.[29]

13. Conclusion on the “theological virtues” in prayer

We have just seen how exercising the virtues of faith, hope, and love is the basis of the prayer life. The firmer our faith, the more confident our hope, the stronger our desire to love, the more our prayer will unite us to God and bear fruit. We do not need anything else.

Faith, hope, and love can be exercised in prayer in countless ways, and I will come back to this subject later on. But we need to take care to center ourselves well on that, and not become obsessed with secondary things or pointless complications. Even if we do not feel anything special, even if our imaginations and intelligences are empty or a little distracted, as long as we are holding ourselves in God's presence with those dispositions of the heart, sometimes reduced to a single, simple attitude of loving trust, our prayer will be fruitful. God will give himself, communicate himself to us in secret, in a manner independent of anything perceptible to our senses and any light in our minds, and he will deposit treasures in our hearts that we will become aware of little by little. Sometimes our prayer is very arid and poor, yet because we are being faithful to God, he teaches us secretly, without our even noticing it. And when it is time for action, for making a choice, giving someone advice, at that moment a light is given to us. St. Thérèse of Lisieux experienced this, as she testifies in this passage:

> To teach souls, Jesus does not need books or learned men; He, the teacher of teachers, teaches us without any words… . I have never heard him speak, but I feel that he is in me at every moment, guiding me and inspiring me on what I ought to say or do. At just the time when I need it, I discover lights that I had not seen before, and very often it is not in my prayers when these lights are most abundant, but rather amidst my ordinary daily occupations.[30]

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1. Matta El Maskine (Father Matta El-Meskeen), *L'Expérience de Dieu dans la vie de prière* (Bé grolles-en-Mauges, France: Abbaye de Bellefontaine, 1997), 30.
2. *The Life of St. Teresa of Avila by Herself*, chapter 19.
3. St. Teresa of Avila, *The Way of Perfection*, chapter 21.
4. "Theological" in this phrase means: that have God as their principal object; and also, that unite us with God.
5. See, for example, 1 Thes 1:3; 5:8; 1 Cor 13:13.
6. *The Ascent of Mount Carmel*, Book 2, chapter 9.
7. She uses this expression in a beautiful passage in Manuscript C, where she (who had only sisters) is describing the intense joy of being given a "younger brother"—a missionary priest entrusted to her prayers. Cf. Manuscript C, 32 recto.
8. Rom 11:33.
9. *Spiritual Canticle*, Prologue.
10. "Mary gives herself completely in a wondrous manner to a person who gives himself to her without reserve." *True Devotion to the Blessed Virgin*, chapter 4.
11. Ibid., chapter 6.
12. Letter 197.
13. *The Dark Night of the Soul*, Book 2, chapter 21.
14. St. Angela of Foligno, *The Book of Visions and Instructions*, chapter 19.
15. St. Teresa of Avila, *Book of the Foundations*, chapter 5.

16. *Autobiography*, chapter 22.
17. This invitation to despise oneself must be correctly understood, especially today when many people, for psychological reasons, tend to despise themselves, belittle themselves or even hate themselves. That has no connection with the humility of the Gospel, which consists, on the contrary, of accepting one's poverty and being reconciled to one's weakness. "Despising oneself" here should be understood as recognizing one's radical poverty while accepting it peacefully with total confidence in God.
18. Catherine de Bar, *Adorer et adhérer* (Paris: Cerf, 1994), 112.
19. Ibid, 116.
20. Letter 197.
21. Catherine de Bar, *Adorer et adhérer*, 113.
22. Ibid., 111.
23. Manuscript C, 16 verso.
24. Jean-René Bouchet (ed.), *Paroles de Chartreux. Perspectives de vie religieuse* (Paris: Cerf, 1987), 99.
25. *Autobiography*, chapter 8.
26. Letter 142 to her sister Celine.
27. Manuscript A, 75 verso.
28. Manuscript C, folio 3 recto.
29. Christiane Sanson, *Marie de la Trinité, de l'angoisse á la paix* (Paris: Cerf, 2005), 83–84.
30. Manuscript A, 83 verso.

CHAPTER III

The Presence of God

Lord my God, you are not distant
from those who do not turn away from you.
How could it be said that you go away?

— JOHN OF THE CROSS[1]

Praying is welcoming someone's presence. So it is helpful to meditate about the ways God makes himself present to us. He does this in many different ways: in creation, in his Word as transmitted to us in the Scriptures, in the mystery of Christ, in the Eucharist, by dwelling in our hearts, etc. These various modes of God's presence are not all of the same nature; they need to be distinguished from one another, and we cannot put them all on the same level. All have their importance, however, and can guide our way of praying. Let's look at them now.

About this we need to be clear: Where God is present, he is also hidden. Whether it is in nature, in the Eucharist, in the center of our souls, God is really present, but by a presence not accessible to human modes of perception. No scrutiny, no psycho-analysis, no scientific experiment, no microscope or scanner, can detect God's presence anywhere. The only "instrument," so to speak, that can access and reveal this presence, is the one discussed at length in the previous chapter: "faith imbued with love," in the words of Sister Marie of the Trinity.

God is intimately present in every reality, and desires nothing more than to reveal himself; but he is a hidden God. "Truly, thou art a God who hidest thyself, O God of Israel, the Savior" (Is 45:15). The only way to bring him out of his hiding place is by searching for him with love. Faith and love "break his cover," whereas all other means are useless. God cannot be found and possessed except by faith and love, because he does not want to be united to us in any other way except a loving encounter.

But by its very nature, love is not subject to material or scientific proof: it can only be taken on trust. We sometimes wish God's presence were more visible, more convincing, we wish we could demonstrate it clearly, so that

unbelievers would be proved wrong; but that is not possible while we journey on this earth. It could not be otherwise, or God would cease to be a God who begs for our love and respects our freedom. God does not want us to be attached to him by anything except love. God reveals himself to us not through manifestations or compelling proofs, but through signs that are often unobtrusive, clues, calls, arousing a free adherence of faith on our part. There is no way to grasp God's presence without an act of faith.

But from the moment the eyes of faith are opened and an act of faith is made sincerely, the whole reality of God's presence and the riches of his love become accessible to us.

Now, without trying to list them all, I want to describe certain aspects of God's presence that are important in orientating our prayer lives.

1. God's presence in nature

God first speaks to us in his creation. He expresses his goodness, power, and wisdom through the world around us. St. John of the Cross often took his novices into the countryside to do their prayer. Father Alexander Men used to say that one leaf of a tree is worth more than a thousand icons—and, coming from a Russian Orthodox priest, that is putting it very strongly indeed.

The leaf comes directly, so to speak, from the Creator's hand. As a child, the future St. John of Kronstadt (also a Russian Orthodox priest), who loved nature deeply, would sometimes stop before a flower, murmuring, "There's God!"[2] Obviously, this is not a question of falling into pantheism—God and his creation are completely distinct from one another—or some kind of sacralization of nature; but in nature we can recognize an imprint of God's love. It is touching to see how all the saints were filled with wonder at the beauty of the world and how they perceived God's love and wisdom in created things. Think of St. Francis of Assisi's *Canticle of the Creatures* and the mystical poems of St. John of the Cross. Both found traces of God's beauty in their contemplating nature.

O forests, dark thickets
Planted by the hand of the Beloved;
O verdant pastures,
Field enameled with flowers,
Tell me if He has passed through you.

Scattering a thousand graces
He passed through these groves in great haste;
He looked at them
And the mere reflection of his face
Left them all clothed in beauty.[3]

Contemporary man is often cut off from nature; he lives in a world that is reduced to a universe of tarmac, concrete, and all kinds of screens. He is the prisoner of a fabricated world, a virtual world, the projection of his own fantasies, instead of being in contact with creation. As a result, he is sometimes cut off from God—and from himself.

Psalm 19 tells us, "The heavens proclaim the glory of God." From biblical times believers have always contemplated God's glory as it is reflected in the beauty of creation. Modern rationalism leaves us incapable of this; and that is a pity, since with the development of so many fields of scientific knowledge, we have a thousand times more reasons than the men of the Bible or the Middle Ages to marvel at God's wisdom and power. The images of distant galaxies sent back to us by the Hubble satellite; the views of the deep-sea world; the astounding things we have learned about the genetic code, the Big Bang, and the structure of the atom—all these are enough to fill believers with wonder, since they know that all this is not the product of chance and necessity but the fruit of God's creative love. This is especially true if we are convinced, as St. Louis-Marie Grignion de Monfort was, that God brings into play more power and wisdom in leading a single soul to salvation than he used in creating the whole universe.[4]

Some years ago I had to take an airplane flight to Lebanon to preach a retreat there. Having nothing to read, I bought a book at the airport. It was by Hubert Reeves: *Dernières nouvelles du Cosmos* ("Latest News of the Cosmos"). I am a scientist by training, but since I entered the Community I had not had a chance to keep up with the latest developments of cosmology research. This book is written by an astrophysicist who is an agnostic but speaks with huge enthusiasm about what twentieth-century science discovered about the origin and development of the universe.

I have to say this book did me more good than ten spiritual books! In it, you learn amazing things, such as that our present universe, extending over billions of light-years, would, at the beginning, have fit onto a pinhead; or that our body is made up of atoms that came into being in stars that exploded at the end of their lives several billion years ago, hurling into the cosmos the matter that would afterwards be used to build the earth and its

inhabitants. On discovering all this, I told myself I had good reason to be very proud of my God!

More simply, the beauty of a sunset on the sea, the graceful game played by squirrels jumping from branch to branch, the splendor of a starry night, are clearly words that God speaks to us so that we will trust him and abandon ourselves fearlessly to his wisdom. Nature contemplated with the eyes of faith has great power to console and strengthen us. Going for a walk in the beautiful countryside, taking in with all our senses the world just as it is given to us, giving thanks for the beauty of earth and sky, can often nourish our prayer, so let's learn to make use of it. Contact with nature can easily become a way of accepting the wise, loving presence of God in our lives and nurturing our love and trust.

2. God gives himself in the humanity of Christ

In the plan of salvation at the heart of Christianity, the essential means by which God makes himself present to mankind is the humanity of Christ. "In him the whole fullness of Deity dwells bodily" (Col 2:9). By the Incarnation of his Son God becomes, in the most powerful way, Emmanuel, God with us.

Everything that in one way or another places us in contact with the humanity of Christ brings us into the presence of God. That includes humbly invoking the name of Jesus, contemplating the events of his life from the Incarnation to his ascension into glory, meditating on his actions and his words, gazing at an icon or a crucifix, holding a friendly conversation with Jesus whom we picture at our side like the best and most faithful of friends, Eucharistic adoration, saying the Rosary, etc. From the time of the Apostles until today, the Christian people, guided by the Holy Spirit and the inventiveness of love, have learned to make Jesus and his life their own in hundreds of thousands of different ways, and in doing so welcome the mystery of God into themselves. This conviction is the beginning of many of the different forms of prayer and devotion that nourish the Church's life.

The humanity of Jesus is the door, one both humble and, unhappily, still hidden from many. This door gives us access to all the riches of the mystery of God, to the fullness of life of the Blessed Trinity. There is no end to what could be said about this; the Church will never finish exploring all the

treasures of light and graces contained in Jesus, and entering into possession of them through faith and love. St. John of the Cross says all the hidden treasures that the Doctors of the Church and the saints have discovered in the humanity of the Word are nothing in comparison with what still remains to be discovered,[5] for “in him are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge of God” (Col 2:3).

Everything that connects us to Christ in one way or another, through the body, the senses, the heart, the mind, and the will, gives us communion with God’s presence and life. It is a fundamental aspect of Christian prayer.

3. God’s presence in our hearts

One of the aspects of God’s presence most decisive with regard to our prayer life is God’s presence in our hearts. I spoke a little about this in the preceding chapter, with the image of the “well,” but I would now like to say more.

It is a truth of faith that God lives in us, with a hidden but real presence. “The Kingdom of God is within you,” says Jesus (Lk 17:21). St. Paul says Christ dwells in our hearts through faith (cf. Eph 3:17) and the body is “the temple of the Holy Spirit” (1 Cor 6:19).

“You are a temple, do not seek a place!” said a medieval Greek monk.[6]

God is present in us because he is our Creator “in whom we live and move and have our being” (Acts 17:28), but also as the presence of grace and love, which become progressively more intense as love grows in our hearts. “If a man loves me, he will keep my word, and my Father will love him, and we will come to him and make our home with him” (Jn 14:23). By baptism the whole Blessed Trinity comes to live in us, and God’s presence is revealed and intensified as our faith and love grow.

The simple but absolutely fundamental consequence of this truth is that recollection—entering into ourselves—is an essential dimension of prayer. We withdraw into ourselves in order to meet God who lives there. His presence is not something we can experience or feel: it is primarily something we believe, an object of faith. But if we make that act of faith and, in accordance with what we believe, make the effort to recollect ourselves often, entering into ourselves to meet God who is waiting for us, faith will little by little become a genuine experience for us. We will know for a fact that we are truly inhabited, in our innermost selves, by an

unfailing source of peace, holiness, purity, and happiness, and that this source is God himself, with all the fullness of his life and gifts.

Before becoming the mystic whom we know, St. Teresa of Avila had huge difficulty, for many years, in praying. She tells how her prayer life was revolutionized by this discovery of the presence of God within her. The following passage is an example:

> Think, then, what St. Augustine says: He searched for God everywhere and finally found him within himself. Do you think it means little to a soul with a tendency to get distracted to comprehend this truth and know she does not need to go to heaven to speak to her Eternal Father and spend time happily with him; to know that she does not need to shout out her prayers as loudly as she can? However softly she speaks, he will hear her; she has no need of wings to fly in search of him, she only needs to go somewhere alone, look inside herself and not be surprised to find such a good guest. In all humility, let her speak to him as to a father, put her requests to him as to a father, find strength in him as in a father, realizing all the time that she is not worthy for him to be her father.[7]

Another example from her writings is this:

> You will certainly laugh at me and say that it is perfectly clear, and you will be right to laugh, because for me it was unclear for some time. I understood that I had a soul, but what that soul merited and who dwelt in it, I did not understand, because the vanities of life covered my eyes with a blindfold. If I had understood, as I do fully now, that in the little palace of my soul such a great King was living, I think I would not have left him alone so often, but from time to time I would have remained in company with him and would have tried to make his palace less dirty. But what could be more marvelous than seeing him who would fill a thousand worlds with his greatness, enclosing himself in such a small thing! That is how he chose to dwell in the womb of his Most Holy Mother. As he is the Lord, he bears freedom within himself, and as he loves us, he fits himself to our measure. When a soul is at the beginning of this road, he does not make himself known, for fear lest she should be upset at seeing herself so small to contain something so great, but little by little, very gently, he enlarges that soul to the measure of what he puts into her. That is why I say he bears freedom within himself, for he has the power to make the palace of the soul greater. The main point is that we must be absolutely determined to give it to him, and that we clear it out so that he can put things in and take things out, as in a house of his own. That is the condition he lays down, and His Majesty is right; let us not refuse to let him.[8]

At the risk of being overlong, I cannot resist the temptation of quoting a beautiful passage from the writings of St. John of the Cross, who expresses the same thing in a very different style:

> Let us realize this fully: the Word, the Son of God, dwells by his essence and his presence, together with the Father and the Holy Spirit, in the very essence of the soul, and is hidden there. The soul that aspires to find him must therefore leave behind, as regards affection and will, all created things; she must enter inside herself and remain there in such profound recollection that all created things are for her as though they did not exist.
>
> God, then, is hidden in our souls, and it is there that the true contemplative must seek him, saying: “Where are you hiding?”

Therefore, O soul, most beautiful of all God's creatures, you who desire so ardently to know where your Beloved is to be found, so that you can find him and unite yourself to him; see, you are given the answer here: you yourself are the place in which he dwells, you are his hiding-place. What joy, what consolation that brings you! Your treasure, the object of your hope, is so close to you that he is within you, or rather you cannot be without him. Listen to the Spouse himself telling you so: "The kingdom of God is within you" (Lk 17:21). And his servant the apostle St. Paul tells us for his part, "We are the temple of the living God" (2 Cor 6:16).

It is a great consolation for a soul to know that God will never leave her. Mortal sin itself does not make him turn away from us. With how much more reason will he make his dwelling in a soul in grace!

What more can you desire, dear soul? What do you seek outside, given that you possess in yourself your riches, your pleasures, your joy, your fulfillment and your kingdom, that is, the Beloved to whom you aspire and who is the object of all your searching? Rejoice, exult in your inner recollection, in the company of him who is so close to you. Adore him within yourself and never try to find him outside.[9]

An endless number of passages from Christian spiritual writers could be quoted, expressing the same wonder and the same invitation to be united by faith to God dwelling in our hearts. There are times in our lives for external action and interpersonal relationships; but we also need to be able to seize the times for separating ourselves from everything in order to seek God inside ourselves, in a simple movement toward silence, recollection, and inward attention to the presence of him who dwells in us.

If we acquire the habit of doing this in a sustained way during our times of mental prayer, but also briefly and frequently in the course of our ordinary working day, we will see that little by little, even in the heat of action, we remain united to God and can draw from his intimate presence all energy, all wisdom, and all peace. Then we no longer live in a superficial, agitated, disorderly, impulsive way, but truly centered on our heart, in which God is dwelling.

It is by being able to separate ourselves from everything and from everyone from time to time, in order to find God inside ourselves, that we will be most effectively united to everything and everyone.

Happy is the soul who has found God in herself, she is happier than if she had conquered the whole world![10]

To conclude, let us note that the true treasure is within. Finding our true riches within us makes us freer with regard to earthly possessions.

4. Praying the Word[11]

Another mode of God's presence is fundamental for the prayer life: his presence in Holy Scripture. God communicates himself through the words of the Bible. God lives in his word; receiving it and meditating on it in our hearts means that we are welcoming the gift of his presence and his love. If someone asks, "What should I do to make the best use of the time I decide to spend praying?" I think that the best answer is to advise them to start from meditation on Scripture. Obviously, this is not meant to exclude other forms of prayer (we will look at some in the next section). But it is good for our prayer to be nourished essentially on the Word of God.

One of the lovely things about the Bible is that God not only addresses us, speaking to our hearts, but also gives us words in which to respond. The Psalms, for instance, contain inexhaustible riches for expressing our prayer and helping us to find the right attitude toward God. Holy Scripture is thus the basis for all genuine dialogue with God. The more our prayer life is nourished on Scripture, the more truthful and profound it will be, and the more it will entail a genuine encounter with God.

In the not-too-distant past Catholics generally made little use of the Bible. We know how much the Second Vatican Council wished to return it to the heart of Catholic life. We only need to recall the words of the constitution *Dei Verbum*:

> The Church has always venerated the divine Scriptures just as she venerates the body of the Lord, since, especially in the sacred liturgy, she unceasingly receives and offers to the faithful the bread of life from the table both of God's word and of Christ's body. She has always maintained them, and continues to do so, together with sacred tradition, as the supreme rule of faith, since, as inspired by God and committed once and for all to writing, they impart the word of God Himself without change, and make the voice of the Holy Spirit resound in the words of the prophets and Apostles. Therefore, like the Christian religion itself, all the preaching of the Church must be nourished and regulated by Sacred Scripture. For in the sacred books, the Father who is in heaven meets His children with great love and speaks with them; and the force and power in the word of God is so great that it stands as the support and energy of the Church, the strength of faith for her sons, the food of the soul, the pure and everlasting source of spiritual life. Consequently these words are perfectly applicable to Sacred Scripture: "For the word of God is living and active" (Heb 4:12) and "it has power to build you up and give you your heritage among all those who are sanctified" (Acts 20:32; see 1 Thes 2:13). Easy access to Sacred Scripture should be provided for all the Christian faithful.[12]

The Council uses strong words here: the Word of God is *the strength of our faith, the food of our souls, the pure and everlasting source of our spiritual life*. It also establishes an analogy between the Eucharist and the Word. The language of the Bible is human language, with, sometimes, its poverty, limitations, and obscurities, but through it God really

communicates himself to us. Meditating on Scripture is much more than reflecting on a text and getting ideas from it; it is welcoming, in a process of prayer and faith, a Presence that gives itself to us. Simply ruminating on single verses of Scripture, if we do it with faith and love, can draw us into profound communion with God. As in the Sacred Host, God gives himself to us as our food in his Word.

Listening to the Word makes us enter God's intimacy. In the lives of a married couple who love each other, their dialogue, the words they exchange, create intimacy, a space for communion and mutual self-giving, sometimes crowned by the reciprocal gift of their bodies. In the same way, listening to the Word, the echoes it awakens in our hearts and the response of prayer, also nourished by Scripture that arises from it, enable a real space of intimacy and mutual self-giving to come into existence between God and the believer.

All of us, every Christian who reads Scripture, seeking God in it, in a humble and sincere action of faith, will from time to time have a wonderful experience: though written many centuries ago in a historical context totally different from our own, this particular passage touches us and speaks to us with extraordinary precision, connects with us in what we are experiencing now, and tells us clearly what we need to hear from God. We truly feel that this text from Isaiah, this verse from one of the psalms or an epistle, was written for us alone!

This experience is not reserved for great mystics or specialists in exegesis; every Christian is called to it. And especially today: our lives as believers are being lived in difficult circumstances and therefore God is opening up the riches of his Word more amply than ever to all the little ones and the poor. I am absolutely convinced that the simplest and most uneducated believer can discover in the Bible treasures of light and wisdom that nobody has discovered before. The Bible speaks to the heart of each, uniquely and personally.

Let me offer a short testimony of my own. Some years ago I was going through a difficult period marked by ennui, discouragement, a painful sense of my own wretchedness… . I went to spend some days in a Benedictine monastery, to place in God's hands my distress, my unanswered questions, etc. Taking part in the Divine Office, I let myself be lulled by the rhythm of the chanted psalms. And there in the course of the psalmody came this verse: "Return, O my soul, to your rest; for the Lord has dealt bountifully

with you" (Ps 116:7). I felt then that through those simple words God was speaking directly to my heart, and I found great comfort and strength in them.

5. Word and discernment

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path, O Lord," says Psalm 119 (v. 105). Regular reading of the Word of God is vital because it alone can shed light on the truth of our lives. This power of discernment possessed by the Word of God is shown clearly in the passage from the Letter to the Hebrews quoted above:

> For the word of God is living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing to the division of soul and spirit, of joints and marrow, and discerning the thoughts and intentions of the heart. And before him no creature is hidden, but all are open and laid bare to the eyes of him with whom we have to do (Heb 4:12–13).

Scripture is like a mirror that enables us to know ourselves truly, both the good and the bad. It denounces our compromises with evil, our ambiguities, our attitudes that contradict the Gospel; but it also brings out the best in us, setting it free and encouraging it. It reaches the division between the soul and the spirit; in other words, it enables us to discern between a psychological construct (stemming from our wounded human nature) and what is spiritual (proceeding from the dynamics of love). Taking up the image of the mirror, St. James invites us to look deeply into the Word, which he calls the "perfect law of liberty" (Jas 1:25), to stay connected with it and find happiness in practicing it.

It is good for us to expose ourselves to the Word of God regularly. It alone can bring about a deep work of discernment and truthfulness in our lives. It is not we who work on the Bible but the Bible that works on us. We need, day after day, to let ourselves be worked upon and shaped by it, by this or that specific passage. That means taking a risk, because the Word can sometimes tell us things we do not want to hear. But ultimately it works for life, freedom, and peace. Whether it corrects us or consoles us, it brings us life. This is what John Paul II said in *Novo Millennio Ineunte*:

> It is especially necessary that listening to the word of God should become a life-giving encounter, in the ancient and ever valid tradition of *lectio divina*, which draws from the biblical text the living word which questions, directs and shapes our lives.

Not everything in Scripture is instantly understandable. We will find some passages obscure and some even shocking. But if our search is sincere, a light will very often be given to us; a particular verse will become clear and speak beautifully to our hearts. The risen Christ will open our minds through his Holy Spirit, as he did for the Apostles, “to understand the Scriptures” (Lk 24:45). This enlightenment can only come little by little, but it is a real experience.

What makes possible this inner illumination that gives us access to the riches of the Word? I think the essential thing is *a genuine desire for conversion*. If we read Scripture while praying, confident that God is awaiting us there, and in a sincere desire for his Word to touch our hearts, show us our sins, lead us to a true conversion, and if we are resolved to put into practice what he tells us, then Scripture will be illuminated for us. That is the main secret of exegesis.

I do not mean to say that other things are pointless. It is also good to do biblical studies if we have the opportunity. Little St. Thérèse of Lisieux would have liked to know Greek and Hebrew. Exegetical training can be extremely valuable. But let us never forget that the treasures of Scripture do not open themselves up to the wise and prudent as much as to those who are seeking just one thing: to love God more and be converted to the Gospel.

6. The Word as a weapon for the fight

This familiarity with God’s Word is all the more necessary, in that it is an essential weapon for the spiritual combat. In the sixth chapter of the Letter to the Ephesians, St. Paul exhorts those to whom he is writing to take up, confidently and courageously, the fight that is an integral part of all genuine Christian life:

> Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might. Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil (Eph 6:10–11).

A little further on Paul describes the different parts of the armor we need to put on to “withstand the evil day and stand firm.” The last—and not the least— thing he refers to is “the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God.”

This invites us to become more fully aware of the place of Holy Scripture as an indispensable help for getting through the combats and trials

of this life.

It is vital to be able to rely on Holy Scripture in the battles we wage. Pope John Paul said a Christian who does not pray is a Christian at risk.[13] Similarly, I would say that a Christian who does not regularly read the Word of God is a Christian at risk. “Man does not live by bread alone, but by everything that proceeds out of the mouth of the Lord” (Dt 8:3). Because of all the confusion in the minds of people around us, and the arguments we are bombarded with by the media, and because of our own weakness, we cannot afford to do without the light and strength that we can draw from the Bible.

The synoptic Gospels, and in particular Mark’s, show how the crowds were struck by the authority of Jesus’ words: “They were astonished at his teaching, for he taught them as one who had authority, and not as the scribes” (Mk 1:22). And a little later: “What is this? A new teaching! With authority he commands even the unclean spirits, and they obey him” (Mk 1:27).

This authority, which makes such an impression on his hearers, has two aspects. The first is that Jesus speaks in his own name, not basing himself on the authority of anyone else. In this way he marks himself out from the usual teaching of the rabbis of his time, who never said anything without referring to the wise men who had preceded them (though adding their individual touch to it, of course). Jesus is not a link in the transmission of the Word; he is the Word itself, in its very source and origin.

The other aspect of the authority of Jesus’ Word is its power and effectiveness. When he casts out a demon, it cannot resist but flees. When he orders the stormy sea, “Peace! Be still!” there is a great calm—not just in the waves but also in the agitated, frightened hearts of his disciples (Mk 4:39). When he tells a poor sinful woman, “Your sins are forgiven” (Lk 7:48), she immediately feels like a different person, purified, reconciled with God and with herself in the depths of her being, clothed in a new dignity, and happy to be who she is.

This authority is not there to crush us: on the contrary, it is authority brought to bear against evil, against our enemies, against the Accuser. It is authority in our favor, for our edification and consolation. It is indispensable for us to learn to rely on this authority of the Word of God, which contains a strength not possessed by any human word.

There will be times when the beneficial authority of God's Word will be our lifeline. At certain moments of trial, the only way to stay on the right track will be to rely, not on our thoughts and reasoning powers (whose basic weakness will become only too clear), but on the words of Scripture. Jesus himself, tempted by the devil in the desert, made use of Scripture to resist him. If we remain at the level of human reasoning and calculation alone, the Tempter will one day prove wilier and stronger than we are. Only the Word of God is capable of disarming him.

We have all had this experience or we will one day. If we stay at the level of reflection at certain times of trouble, doubt, or trial, we won't find any way out. If, for example, we try to calm our fears when worried about the future by working out things for ourselves, we risk ending in a total impasse. For, between our reasons for worrying and the reasons we use to reassure ourselves, we can never be quite sure which set of reasons will win out in the end—reason, after all, can't foresee and master everything. Rather than pile up more and more arguments, the only way to come out on the positive side (the side of confidence, hope and peace) is to let a phrase from Scripture enter our consciousness and rely on it with full faith: "Do not be anxious about tomorrow" (Mt 6:34), for example, or "Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father's good pleasure to give you the kingdom" (Lk 12:32), or "Even the hairs of your head are all numbered" (Lk 12:7).

True peace does not come as the result of a process of human reasoning. It can only come from having our hearts attached to the promises God makes us through his Word. When, in times of doubt or confusion, we cling by an act of faith to a promise in Scripture, the authority of that Word becomes our support and strength. It is not a magic wand that renders us immune to all complexity and anguish. But in trusting adherence to God's Word, we find a mysterious strength that nothing else can provide. It has a special power to establish us in hope and peace, no matter what happens. Referring to God's promise to Abraham, the Epistle to the Hebrews explains that "in all disputes an oath is final for confirmation" (Heb 6:16). The Word of God, received in faith, has the power to put an end to our indecision and the vacillation of our reasoning, and establish us firmly in truth and peace. The hope brought by this Word is "a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul" (Heb 6:19).

Scripture contains countless passages that can be a valuable support for us in our struggles. If we feel alone and abandoned, Scripture tells us, "Can

a woman forget her sucking child, that she should have no compassion on the son of her womb? Even these may forget, yet I will not forget you" (Is 49:15). If we feel that God is far away, Scripture says, "I am with you always, to the close of the age" (Mt 28:20). If we feel crushed by our sins, it responds, "I will not remember your sins" (Is 43:25). If we feel that we lack the resources we need to advance in life, one of the psalms invites us to make this act of faith: "The Lord is my shepherd, I shall not want" (Ps 23:1).

Do not allow a single day to go by, then, without taking at least a few minutes to meditate on a passage of Scripture. It may sometimes appear to be dry or obscure, but if we read it faithfully, in simplicity and prayer, it will sink deep into our memory without our even realizing it. And on the day when we need it, in a time of adversity, that verse or some other will return to our minds and will be precisely what we need to recover our hope and peace.

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1. Maxim 50 (or 47, or 68), *Sayings of Light and Love*.
2. Jean de Cronstadt, *Ma vie en Christ* (Abbaye de Bellefontaine, 1979), 11; cf. John of Kronstadt, *My Life in Christ* (Cassell & Co. Ltd, 1897), 36.
3. *Spiritual Canticle*, strophes 4 and 5.
4. See the beginning of *The Secret of Mary*.
5. *Spiritual Canticle*, strophe 37.
6. Quoted in (Anon.), *La Prière de Jésus* (Chevetogne, 1963), 34.
7. *Way of Perfection*, chapter 28.
8. Ibid.
9. *Spiritual Canticle* B, I, 6–8.
10. Catherine de Bar, *Adorer et adhérer*, 36.
11. In this section I take up a point that I reflected on at length in chapter 3 of my book *Called to Life*.
12. *DeIVerbum*, 21–22.
13. *Novo Millennio Ineunte*, no. 34.

CHAPTER IV

Practical Advice for Personal Prayer

"The supreme good is prayer,
familiar conversation with God."[1]

In this chapter I want to give some practical advice for personal prayer. It should of course be received with great freedom and adapted to each particular situation. The important thing is to launch out, throw oneself into the water, so to speak, and discover little by little which type of prayer the Holy Spirit is leading us to. There are all sorts of different calls and graces in this area, and it is up to all of us to open ourselves to the particular gift given to us.

I will start with some remarks about the link between our times of prayer and the rest of life.

1. Outside the time of prayer

The quality of personal prayer is obviously conditioned by how we live our lives outside our times of prayer. We cannot unite ourselves to God in times of prayer if we are not seeking to be united to him in all our other activities, by doing them in his presence, seeking to please him and do his will, entrusting our choices and decisions to him, letting ourselves be guided by the light of the Gospel in choosing among options, acting out of disinterested love, and so on.

Conversely, as we have seen, regularly spending time in prayer leads to an intensification of the dispositions of faith, hope, and love, which are valuable not only at the time of prayer itself, but should be the support and basic orientation of our whole lives and each of our actions.

Much could be said about the two-way connection between prayer and the rest of life, but I wish to stress just two points: living in God's presence and practicing charity.

As to the first, let's make the effort to make the whole of our lives little by little into a dialogue with God. Do this simply, being adaptable about it, with no tension, but in a quest for constant communion with him. Not necessarily feeling anything in particular, but bringing into play the attitudes of faith, hope, and charity of which I spoke earlier.

Everything without exception that makes up our lives can nourish our dialogue with God: a quick thank you for the good things; to ask him for help with our worries; to invoke the light of his Spirit in making difficult decisions; and so on. And of course, to tell him we are sorry and ask his forgiveness for our sins! We need to turn everything to good account. God does not ask us primarily for perfection, but to live our lives with him.

I quote a few sentences from Brother Lawrence of the Resurrection, a seventeenth-century Carmelite friar in Paris, the cook and shoemaker of his monastery, a simple man, but endowed with great wisdom, whose whole spiritual life was summed up in this desire to live in every moment, place, and circumstance in God's presence.

> The practice that is holiest, most usual and most necessary in the spiritual life is the practice of the presence of God. That is, to take pleasure in and to accustom ourselves to his divine company, speaking humbly and conversing lovingly with him at all times, at every moment, without rule or measure; and especially at times of temptations, sufferings, dryness, and self-disgust, and even infidelities and sins. We should apply ourselves continually to ensure that all our activities whatsoever are a way of holding little conversations with God, not studied words, but just as they come forth from purity and simplicity of heart… .
>
> We should, during our work and other actions, even during our reading, even spiritual reading, during our outward devotions and vocal prayers, stop for an instant as often as we can, to adore God in the depths of our hearts, savor him rapidly and as it were by stealth, praise him, ask him for help, offer him our hearts and thank him. What could be more pleasing to God than for us to leave aside created things a thousand times a day, to recollect ourselves and adore him interiorly?
>
> For being with God, it is not necessary to be always at church. We may make an oratory of our heart, wherein to retire from time to time, to converse with him. Everyone is capable of such familiar conversation with God.

The second point that needs stressing is the importance of the specific exercise of charity as an indispensable condition for growth in our prayer life. How could we expect to find God and be united to him in prayer, if we are indifferent to the needs of our neighbor? Here is what St. Teresa of Avila says:

> When I see souls applying themselves diligently to examining their prayer, so wrapped up in it that they hardly dare to move or think of anything else for fear lest a little of their pleasure or fervor should be taken from them, I conclude that they completely misunderstand by which road one attains union [with God], and think that the whole question is reduced to that alone. But no, my Sisters, no.

Our Lord wants works; if you see a sick person to whom you can bring some relief, it should matter little to you whether you will lose your fervor: take pity on her. If she suffers, suffer with her; and if necessary, fast, going without food so that she can eat instead of you; less for her sake, than because you know that that is what our Lord wants. Such is true union with his Will.[2]

Lack of love for our neighbor, shutting our hearts to their needs, voluntarily nurturing resentment or bitterness toward someone, refusal to forgive—these things can render our prayer sterile, and we need to be aware of it.

By contrast, acts of mercy and kindness toward neighbor redound to the benefit of our relationship with God, especially in our prayer. We should not forget the magnificent promises made in chapter 58 of Isaiah to those who practice love for their neighbor:

Is not this the fast that I choose: … to share your bread with the hungry, and bring the homeless poor into your house; when you see the naked, to cover him, and not to hide yourself from your own flesh? Then shall your light break forth like the dawn, and your healing shall spring up speedily; your righteousness shall go before you, the glory of the Lord shall be your rear guard… . If you pour yourself out for the hungry and satisfy the desire of the afflicted, then shall your light rise in the darkness and your gloom be as the noonday. And the Lord will guide you continually, and satisfy your desire with good things, and make your bones strong; and you shall be like a watered garden, like a spring of water, whose waters fail not (Is 58:6–11).

If we want the garden of our heart to be well watered by God's grace, let's love our neighbor with deeds!

I spoke above about different modes of God's presence. There is one I have not yet talked about but upon which the Gospel lays much stress: the presence of God in the poor, in the person who needs us.

Truly, I say to you, as you did it to one of the least of these my brethren, you did it to me (Mt 25:40).

If we are able to discern Jesus' presence in our brothers and sisters, we will find it easier to discover him also in our prayer. And the opposite is also true.

Times of dryness, absence of perceptible joy in prayer, can sometimes be a call to look for God's presence elsewhere, especially in acts of charity. This does not mean we should give up praying, but that Jesus is also waiting for us somewhere else and we need to be more attentive to his presence in those who need our love, especially the poor and the little ones. Let's not forget either that there are sometimes illusions in prayer, but not in charity. We find God conclusively when we are taking care of our neighbor.

At the end of her life St. Thérèse of Lisieux endured a very hard trial of faith and hope. She was invaded by temptations that took away all the joy she had had in regard to these matters. Surprisingly, it was in that same period that she rediscovered, very forcefully, the importance of fraternal charity.

> This year, Mother dearest, our good God has given me the grace to understand what charity is; I understood it before, it's true, but in an imperfect way.[3]

This was in 1897, the year of her death… . The last great lights received by our little Doctor of the Church concerned the mystery of charity, which she practiced with a new fervor in the last period of her life, and about which she wrote some magnificent things.[4]

We can now begin our consideration of the time dedicated to prayer with an initial remark: we should aim to make this prayer time part of the rhythm of our lives.

2. Establishing a rhythm

Human life is made up of rhythms: the rhythm of breathing, the rhythm of days and nights, weeks and years… . If we want to be faithful to prayer, it must find its place in our life's rhythms. Praying at a particular time of day, reserving a set point in the week for God, etc., should become habitual. Habit may be a matter of routine or laziness, but it can also be a strength. It means we don't start sorting things out all over again, don't need to ask ourselves each time what we are doing or not doing.

If prayer is a now and then activity, if we put off praying until we have time, we will only pray very little and superficially. We need to take time for prayer and inscribe it among the rhythms of our life, like all the other activities we consider essential: meals, sleep, etc. Nobody has ever starved to death because he or she didn't have time to eat! To say we don't have time to pray simply means prayer is not one of our priorities. Therefore, we each need to establish a certain rhythm of prayer in our daily or weekly lives—without being rigid about it, and always giving priority to urgent demands of charity. There needs to be sufficient frequency to it, while compatible with our family and professional responsibilities. For example, twenty minutes of meditation every morning or every evening, an hour of

adoration in church on Thursdays at the end of the afternoon, an afternoon of spiritual retreat once a month, etc.

Obviously we don't all have the same opportunities. It will be easier for someone who is retired than for someone with a very busy life. We should do what we can; as I said before, God can give someone who can spend only ten minutes a day in prayer but is taken up with work that is God's will, as much as he gives a monk who prays five hours a day.

But we should have the courage to make the right choices. In 2012 the average person in the U.S. spent more than five hours a day in front of the television! It would hardly be life-threatening for someone to cut back on TV in order to spend a little more time with our good God. We shouldn't let ourselves fall into the trap of the devil, who will always do all he can—and offer a thousand good arguments—to keep us from praying. Realize, too, that what we give God will be returned to us a hundredfold!

3. Beginning and ending prayer

Now let's think more closely about the time we've chosen to spend praying. How should we manage this time? Some simple remarks may be helpful.

To begin with: we must take great care of the beginning and great care of the end, and in between do what we can!

The beginning is important. What counts most is to put ourselves truly in God's presence. Depending on circumstances, we can think of God present in our hearts or imagine Christ as a friend we're with, or place ourselves under the loving eyes of our Father in heaven, or look at the Eucharist with eyes full of faith (if it is in a time of Eucharistic adoration).

This deliberate act of putting ourselves in God's presence sometimes requires an effort. We have to lay our worries aside, along with everything else we have on our minds or occupying our imaginations, in order to turn resolutely to face God and direct our attention and love to him. Before doing that, a sort of "airlock moment" to clear our heads can sometimes help us to rid ourselves of any agitation and enter into prayer: a five-minute walk, some moments of relaxation or deep breathing, a calm cup of tea. Sometimes our time of prayer must be preceded by a sort of psychological threshold that eases the transition from everyday stress to this very different kind of activity, made up largely of receptivity, which is prayer.

Putting ourselves in God's presence at the beginning of the prayer can often be made easier by the use of some habitual practices, a little "rite" of our own that launches the time of prayer: lighting a candle in front of an icon; prostrating ourselves; invoking the Holy Spirit; reciting a well-loved psalm; a prayer to our Blessed Lady entrusting this time of prayer to her… . It depends on what God inspires in each of us and what we find helpful.

Let me say a word now about the end of the prayer. My first piece of advice is, as a general rule, to give as much time to praying as you had decided to give. For example, if the decision was for half an hour's prayer every day, that half hour should not be cut short (unless, by exception, because of extreme tiredness or an urgent requirement of charity). One reason for this is faithfulness: if we have decided to give something to God, we should not claw it back. Also, if we cut short prayer too easily when we find it boring, we sometimes may miss the best part of it, rather like leaving the table before the dessert. Not always but sometimes it's in the last minutes of prayer that God visits us. He has seen our fidelity, and even though our prayer has been poor and difficult up to then, in the closing minutes we sense God's presence and are granted a simple grace of peace, encouragement, or satisfaction of heart. It would be a shame to deprive oneself of that.

Another piece of advice is never to be discontented with our prayer. Even if it was difficult, even if we feel we've done no good at all because we were dry, distracted the whole time, fell asleep, and so on, we should still be happy with it. We have spent time with God, and that is enough. We did nothing on our side, but he certainly did something in us, and we can thank him for it with an act of humility and faith. Whatever our prayer was like, the last word of it should always be an *act of thanksgiving*. Little by little we will see that we are not mistaken.

As we come to the end of our prayer, but before that final act of thanksgiving, it is not a bad idea either to make some specific resolutions. Perhaps during the time of prayer some verse of Scripture touched us, a particular truth was imprinted on us, or a definite call made itself felt. Then it is good to resolve to make what we have perceived a part of our lives and entrust ourselves to God, asking him to help us follow up the invitation that our time of prayer awakened in our hearts. If afterwards we are not fully faithful to that resolution, we should not be discouraged. God sees our good desire and that is what matters most. Good resolutions are not made so

much to be kept, in a voluntaristic way, as to express a desire, a thirst, which God himself will bring to fruition in his own good time.

I conclude this point with something from St. Thérèse of Lisieux. Particularly at the time of thanksgiving after Holy Communion, however much she tried to do her best to welcome Jesus into her soul, invoking Mary's help, she often had problems with dryness or falling asleep in her prayer. This was her reaction:

> All of that does not prevent distractions and sleepiness from coming upon me, but when I finish the thanksgiving, seeing that I have done it so badly, I take the resolution to spend the rest of the day giving thanks… . You see, dearest Mother, that I am far from being led along the road of fear, I am always able to find a way to be happy and to profit from my wretchedness… . Undoubtedly that does not displease Jesus, because he seems to encourage me along this path.[5]

4. The time of prayer itself

Let's talk now about the "body" of the prayer, between putting ourselves in God's presence and the conclusion. What can we do to occupy this time in the best possible way?

The answer may be very different, depending on the person concerned, the stage his or her life has reached, and the calls the Spirit makes.

First of all, the essential thing is to get started and keep going. If we do that with good will and fidelity, God will be able to lead us; we can trust him totally.

That said, however, I offer some pieces of advice, to be taken in great freedom of spirit. I can only give some general indications. Then each person must little by little find his or her own way of praying. Readers can take whatever helps them from what follows and leave the rest without worrying about it.

I offer two suggestions, one on the human plane and one on the spiritual plane.

On the human and psychological plane, use what will favor recollection. And what is recollection? A combination of two things: first, a state of release of tension, relaxation, receptivity; second, a state of attentiveness to a reality toward which we are totally orientated.

To be recollected in prayer, then, we need to pause, to abandon ourselves; and at the same time, to be attentive to God's presence in one of the modes I mentioned earlier. For example, we are in a church, we are

calm and peaceful, and we are totally directed, as regards the attention of our hearts, toward the Blessed Sacrament exposed. Or again, sitting in a corner of our room, we read a Gospel passage calmly and peacefully, and dispose ourselves to welcome what the passage tells us, receiving it into our memory.

Except in cases of a special grace, total recollection is not generally possible. But we should aim for it insofar as it depends on us. There is active recollection: doing our best, according to our present capacity, to be quiet, both physically (relaxed, without tension or strain on the body), psychologically (leaving aside concerns and worries), and spiritually (abandoning ourselves to God); and to center ourselves on God's presence in the Word on which we are meditating, in the Eucharist we are adoring, in our own hearts, into which we descend to find him; and so on, as outlined earlier, depending on the direction our prayer takes.

In this pursuit of active recollection, what favors physical and psychological calm is not without importance. We shouldn't focus on it so much that we turn the time of prayer into a psycho-physical technique—that would be a serious mistake. But we are embodied beings, and our physical side does influence our spiritual side. A relaxed physical position; gentle, steady breathing that we are aware of; a way of centering ourselves on the present moment, feeling at ease with our bodies: all of this can facilitate prayer. The key to it is to tend toward a state of receptivity.

We may progressively receive the grace of a recollection that I will call "passive" since it is not the result solely of what we do but is a gift from God, a supernatural grace. It is a state of profound peace, abandonment, and intense attention to something that God makes us perceive of himself, which may come upon us in different degrees. We may be gently touched, just brushed by grace, or completely swept away, or anything in between. We realize that the attention to God involved here is more an act of the will, of the heart, of love, than an act of the mind. As the quotation above by Christiane Sanson put it, it is easier for our hearts to center on God by their love, than it is for our minds, which are more mobile, find it much harder to focus on one thing, and are almost always subject to distractions. A certain degree of attention on the part of the mind is obviously necessary to awaken and foster love, but without a special grace it is not usually possible to fix one's mind completely in a state of attention to God. Wanting to do so at all

costs would even be dangerous, since it would be a source of mental tension and fatigue.

On the spiritual level, as I said at length earlier, we must always bear in mind that what is essential is not this or that method or way of proceeding but the inner dispositions of the heart: faith, trust, humility, acceptance of one's weakness, desire to love … all the many ways of "unpacking" faith, hope, and love. Every method of prayer has as its goal to nurture, sustain, and express these basic attitudes. Suppose that, as we sometimes have the grace to do (because it is a grace—it surpasses our human capacity), we hold ourselves there before God in silence and calmness, without any particular ideas occurring to us, without feeling anything special, but in a profound and simple attitude, a directing of our heart toward God in a single act that combines faith, hope, and love; that would be enough. We do not need to look for anything else: that is enough for there to be real communication with God, and for its fruits to appear, sooner or later.

A word about bodily attitudes: Prayer is not a form of corporal penance. Positions that are too uncomfortable, in which the body is constantly complaining to the mind, are obviously not to be recommended. We should take positions we can hold for some time that favor the state of recollection. That said, there can be times in prayer when, to awaken our attention, to express a loving desire, formulate a petition or other inner disposition, we feel a need to reinforce the inner attitude by exteriorizing it in a specific position or gesture: by kneeling, prostrating ourselves, joining our hands, opening them, lifting them, kissing our Bible, etc. It does us good to use these means—with due discretion and common sense, of course. When the spirit expresses itself through the body, it is strengthened. There is a "body language" that has its place in prayer, not only liturgical prayer but also personal.[6] This needs rediscovering in the Western world, where prayer has too often been made into a purely intellectual exercise that neglects to use the body's resources. Right attitude of body leads to right attitude of heart.

The correct Christian understanding is not that being spiritual means escaping from or being detached from the body but rather involves dwelling in it fully. The body brings us into contact with the reality around us and is our primary medium of communication. Dwelling in the body obliges us to have a healthy realism that is essential to the spiritual life. It is also a precondition for living in the present moment. The body has its own poverty, difficulties, and constraints, but it has the great advantage of being

firmly rooted in reality, in the present. It enables us as it were to “anchor” the spirit and insist that it live in the present. There is a humble wisdom in the human body to which the spirit should submit. We can meet God in prayer only by situating ourselves in the present, and the fact that we are bodily beings is a valuable help toward this. To pray we need to dwell in our hearts, and to dwell in our hearts, we need to dwell in our bodies.

5. When the question “What should I do?” does not arise

In discussing the question “What should one do during one’s times of prayer?” I shall start by clearing the ground and dealing with circumstances in which that question does not arise.

To begin with, then: the more our love for God grows, the less we need to ask what to do during the time of prayer. Two people who love each other intensely don’t usually have much difficulty knowing how to spend their time together. Love answers many questions! We should, therefore, keep asking for more love, we should “cry to God day and night” (as in the Gospel of St. Luke, 18:7), asking that he give us a new heart. Blessed are those who can say, like the spouse in verse 20 of the *Spiritual Canticle* of St. John of the Cross, “In my prayer, ‘now, my sole occupation is to love.’ ” This love is of more worth, and more benefit to the Church, than all the good works in the world, St. John adds.

There are times when for various reasons prayer comes spontaneously. We may be in a state of great fervor (often the case after a major grace of conversion or an outpouring of the Spirit), and then we are perfectly happy to pray and have thousands of things to say to our Lord. Sometimes, too, our prayer comes out straight away because we are in a state of such distress that our whole life becomes one unceasing supplication—and after all, that too is a grace!

There is another circumstance when we don’t have to ask ourselves, “What should I do?” This is when God has begun to introduce us into a certain grace of *contemplative prayer*. There is a particular need to speak of this, since grace of this sort can be almost imperceptible in its beginnings and we may have scruples about remaining in a state that is more passive than active. But in such cases such an attitude is what God is asking of us, and that is what then unites us to him most profoundly and truly.[7]

It is not easy to describe in words, but this much at least can be said by way of description. We are in a state of inner poverty, of great dryness; we feel no intense spiritual emotions, nor are there even any particular lights that fill our mind. However, we have a definite inclination to remain peacefully, restfully, before God, without doing much, but with a certain satisfaction at being there in his presence. Our mind and imagination wander somewhat to left and right as usual, and are far from being fixed on one spot, but with regard to our heart, we feel that it has a definite orientation, a loving attention to God, which is fairly general, not fixed on any one particular point (such as a truth or an aspect of the Christian mystery). This loving, general attention to God is above and beyond precise ideas, images, or discursive lines of thought.

If we are in this state, we should remain there. Our sole activity will perhaps be to maintain it gently and peacefully, by making a little act from time to time to redirect our heart toward God or adverting to a brief consideration to enkindle our faith, hope, or love or else sharing some simple words that express to God what we have in our hearts. We act rather like birds first flapping their wings, then letting themselves glide. Sometimes all we need do is follow the movements that the Holy Spirit may stir during and through our receptive prayer.

There are times in prayer when we need to be active and work at developing it lest we fall into spiritual laziness. But there are also times—and we should learn to recognize them—when the Holy Spirit invites us to leave aside all activity and place ourselves more passively under his soothing presence, his blessing, in a simple attitude of interior availability. We should be there, in the words of St. John of the Cross, in “a sweet breath of love.” This attitude seems to me to be well described in Psalm 131:

> O Lord, my heart is not lifted up, my eyes are not raised too high;
> I do not occupy myself with things too great and too marvelous for me.
> But I have calmed and quieted my soul, like a child quieted at its mother’s breast; like a child that is quieted is my soul.
> O Israel, hope in the Lord from this time forth and for evermore!

This contemplative prayer is something that comes much more as a grace, a particular gift, than as the result of human effort to recollect ourselves and nurture our prayer. But I think it is given to very many souls.

6. When we need to be active in our prayer

When we are not in one of the situations in which prayer flows without effort, either as a spontaneous dialogue or because we have been favored with the grace of contemplative recollection, then we need to be more active. Otherwise there is the danger of spiritual laziness and wasting our prayer time.

I don't propose to explore in detail all the possibilities offered us for occupying our time of prayer. Spiritual writers give many different pointers. Here I limit myself to two "paths" present in the tradition of the Church that I think are practical and can be recommended.

We can use both, depending on inclination, circumstances, and their suitability for particular times. These two ways are *meditation on Scripture* and the different forms of *repetitive prayer*.

7. Meditating on Scripture

Here we are in touch with the very ancient tradition of *lectio divina*, reading Scripture with the aim of finding God and opening ourselves to what he wants to tell us through it here and now. *Lectio divina* can take different directions and various forms. At present I am speaking of it as a method of prayer.[8]

Times and the best time

The best time for *lectio divina* is the morning if that is possible. One's spirit is fresher and better disposed then, normally less loaded with cares and concerns, than at the end of the day. Psalm 90 says, "Satisfy us in the morning with thy steadfast love, that we may rejoice and be glad all our days." And the book of Isaiah says, "The Lord … provides me with speech. Each morning he wakes me to hear, to listen like a disciple" (Is 50:4).

Another advantage of doing the *lectio divina* in the morning is that this testifies that the most urgent thing in our lives is disposing ourselves to listen to God. This practice also establishes us, right from the start of the day, in an inner attitude of listening. That enables us more easily to preserve

the attitude of availability throughout the day and so perceive more readily the calls that God may make to us.

That said, this advice is obviously not set in stone. Clearly, many people do not have the opportunity for it in the morning and can only do it at some other time of day. That won't prevent God from speaking to them if they are thirsty for him.

Which passage should we take for meditation?

There are all sorts of possibilities. We can meditate on a text continuously (one of the Gospels, a Letter of St. Paul, or another book from the Bible) day after day. I know a married layman with a family who, every morning, spends time in prayer based on the Word of God. He has spent two or three years on St. John's Gospel.

However, the advice I give people who are beginners in this field is, on the whole, to do their *lectio* by taking the passages that the Church gives for the Readings of Mass each day. That has the advantage of putting us in harmony with the life of the universal Church and the liturgical times and seasons, and preparing us for the Eucharist if we are going to participate in it. Furthermore we will have three different well-chosen texts (the First Reading, the Psalm, the Gospel), which reduces the risk of being confronted with passages that are too dry or hard to interpret. It is very rare for at least one of the three passages not to speak to us.

Often, too, doing *lectio divina* while looking at several different passages together helps us grasp the profound unity of Scripture. When reading the Bible it is a great joy to discover how often passages that are very different from one another in style, date of composition, content, etc., can, when brought together, reveal new harmonies and shed light on one another. When interpreting passages of Scripture, the wise men in the Rabbinic tradition loved to bring out the richness of their meaning by "stringing necklaces" whose pearls were verses taken from different parts of Scripture — the Torah, the Prophets, Psalms, and Wisdom literature. This is what Jesus himself did for the disciples after his Resurrection, as we see in St. Luke's Gospel (Lk 24:27, 44). The tradition of bringing together different passages to illuminate one another has been continued by all the Fathers of the Church and spiritual commentators up to the present day.

How exactly should we go about it?

As I have already emphasized, the fruitfulness of *lectio divina* depends on our inner attitudes and not the effectiveness of some particular method. Therefore it is important to not begin by starting straight in on the Scripture passage but only after having taken sufficient preparation time to enter into the appropriate dispositions of prayer, faith, and desire. Following are some steps that might be taken in doing that.

As with every time when we start to pray, we should begin by recollecting ourselves, putting ourselves in God's presence. We should leave aside our worries and concerns; the one thing necessary for us, as for Mary of Bethany, is to sit at our Lord's feet and listen to his words.[9] To do that, we need to situate ourselves in the present moment, which we sometimes have great difficulty doing. When necessary, we do well to use the resources of our body and sensations for this purpose. Sometimes it is beneficial to begin with a physical preparation before starting to read: close our eyes, center ourselves in our bodies, relax (loosen our shoulders and any tense muscles), become aware of our breathing and breathe gently but deeply; feel the contact of our bodies with the material world around us—the contact of our feet with the ground, our bodies with the seat, arms with the table, hands with the Bible or missal we are going to use for our reading. The first contact with the Word should be a physical contact. Touching it is already a form of listening. St. John speaks of "That which … we have … touched with our hands, concerning the word of life" (1 Jn 1:1).

Once we feel relaxed, connected with our body, centered on the present moment, we should turn our heart toward God, to thank him in advance for the time he is granting us in which he will contact us through his Word. We should ask him for light, beg him to open our minds to understand the Scriptures (Lk 24:45) as he did for his disciples, and, above all, ask him that this word may truly visit us in depth, convert our heart, lay bare the ways we compromise with sin, enlighten us and transform us where we need it today, so that we may be more fully in tune with God's plan for our life. We should ask him to stir up our desire and will for all this.

When we are ready—and do not hesitate to take time over this, because it is essential—we can open our eyes and begin to read the passage we have chosen for the *lectio divina*. Read slowly, applying mind and heart to what is read and meditating on it.

But realize that “meditating” in the biblical tradition (e.g., Psalm 1, “Blessed is the man who meditates on the law of the Lord day and night”) means not so much reflecting as murmuring, repeating, ruminating. To begin with, it is more of a physical activity than an intellectual one. When a verse attracts our attention we should not fear to repeat it over and over again, because it is often through such rumination that it will release its deep meaning, what God wants to say to us today through that verse.

Of course, the intelligence also has a part to play. We can question the passage. What does it tell me about God? What is it telling me about myself? What good news does it contain? What specific invitation for my life can I find in it? If a verse seems obscure, we can consult notes or a commentary, but we should avoid turning the time of *lectio* into a time of intellectual study.

We should not hesitate to dwell at length on a verse that takes on a particular savor for us and to enter into dialogue with God based on what it is saying to us. The *lectio* should become prayer—giving thanks for an encouraging verse, invoking God’s help when a passage invites us to a conversion that we find difficult, etc. At certain times, if the grace is given us, we can stop our reading and remain in an attitude of more contemplative prayer, simple wonder, and admiration at the beauty of what God makes us discover through the text. A verse may, for instance, convey a deep sense of God’s gentleness or his majesty or his faithfulness or the splendor of what he does in Christ, and it invites us to contemplate that and give thanks for it.

The ultimate goal of the *lectio* is not to read miles and miles of texts, but to lead us as far as possible into the attitude of contemplative wonder, which nourishes our faith, hope, and love. That is not always given, but when it is, we should be able to interrupt our reading and content ourselves with a simple loving presence before the mystery revealed to us in the text.

In what has just been said, we can see the four stages of the *lectio divina* in the tradition of the Middle Ages: *Lectio* (reading), *Meditatio* (meditation), *Oratio* (prayer), and *Contemplatio* (contemplation). These are not so much successive stages to be followed in just that order as they are particular modes of doing *lectio divina*. That is all the more apparent from the fact that, while the first three involve human activity, the fourth is not something we can do at will: it is a gift of grace, which we should desire and welcome but which is not always granted. Moreover, as I said earlier,

there may be times of aridity and dryness, as in any kind of prayer. We must never get discouraged—one who seeks will always end by finding.

Another piece of advice: in the course of meditation, it is good to make a note of some of the words that have made a particular impression on us in a notebook kept for this purpose. Writing them down helps the Word to penetrate more deeply into our heart and memory.

Once the time of *lectio* is over, thank our Lord for the time spent with him, ask him for the grace to be able to keep his Word in our heart, like our Blessed Lady, and resolve to put into practice the particular lights we have received in this time of meditation.

I conclude with a beautiful passage from the Coptic monk Father Matta El Maskine:

> Meditation is not only vocal reading in depth; it also includes the silent repetition of the Word many times over, with ever-growing depth until the heart is enflamed with the divine fire. That is well illustrated by what David says in Psalm 39: "My heart became hot within me, and as I mused, the fire burned." Here appears the slender, secret thread that links our practice and effort to the grace of God. The mere fact of meditating on God's Word many times over, slowly and calmly, ends up, by God's mercy and grace, enflaming our heart! Thus meditation becomes the first normal link between the sincere effort at prayer and the gifts of God and his indescribable grace. For this reason, meditation has been considered as the first and most important of the degrees of the prayer of the heart, starting from which we can rise to fervor of spirit and live there all our lives.[10]

One final remark on this subject. Instead of Scripture, meditation on a spiritual work or the writings of a saint that make a particular impact on us at this point in our lives can sometimes be used as the basis for prayer. There is nothing at all wrong with that. But at the same time let's not deprive ourselves of direct contact with Holy Scripture; it can be more difficult, but it has a blessed effect and reveals treasures far richer than any human writing.

8. Toward continual prayer

Now let us consider a path of access to contemplative prayer different from meditation on Scripture—not opposed to it but complementary. I mean the various traditions of repetitive prayer, such as the "Jesus Prayer" (or "prayer of the heart") and the Rosary. They have the advantage of being simple and able to be used during the time of prayer and also outside it, so that prayer can little by little fill the whole of our lives. I have made this point before, but I would like to come back to it now.

Believers have always sought continual prayer. From Old Testament times, we have this aspiration: “Blessed is the man whose delight is in the law of the Lord, and on his law he meditates day and night” (Ps 1:2); “Oh, how I love thy law! It is my meditation all the day” (Ps 119:97). It is still more evident in the Christian world, where many people have chosen to respond to our Lord’s call, “Pray without ceasing!” (see 1 Thes 5:17).

Christians cannot be content with having regular, set times of prayer. We should seek to pray constantly, to be always in a state of union with God, of love and adoration, because here is where we find our true life. God does not stop loving us and thinking about us, so it is right that we should want to do the same for him and live permanently in his presence. “Walk before me,” he asked our father Abraham (Gn 17:1).

It is good to think about God as often as possible, to love and adore him ceaselessly in our hearts. “I really believe that I have never gone for more than three minutes without thinking about God,” said St. Thérèse of Lisieux. We should desire to achieve a sort of continual attention of the heart to God’s presence in the middle of our ordinary occupations. That is not easy, because we are so distracted! It is a long-term task, requiring a particular sort of assistance from God’s grace. We will never achieve it perfectly, but it is good to aim for it, since that is where true happiness is to be found.

This is how Father Matta El Maskine describes the converging efforts to be made with this aim in mind:

- Stir up our sense of being in the presence of God who sees everything we do and hears everything we say.
- Try to talk to him from time to time, with short phrases that express what we feel at that moment.
- Involve God in our work by asking him to be present in our activities, reporting back to him when we finish them, thanking him when we succeed, and telling him we are sorry when we fail, while seeking the reasons: did we turn our back on him, or neglect to ask for his help?
- Try to hear God’s voice through the work we do. He often speaks to us interiorly, but because we are not attending to him, we miss most of his guidance.
- At crisis moments, such when we receive alarming news or when we are attacked, let us also ask him to help us; in trials he is our closest friend and surest advisor.

- The moment we begin to feel irritated or upset, let us turn to him to calm this harmful agitation before it pervades our heart; envy, anger, judgment, revenge: all this would make us lose the grace of living in his presence, for God cannot dwell together with evil.
- Try as much as we can not to forget him, returning to him the moment we realize our thoughts are wandering.
- Let us not undertake a piece of work or give an answer before receiving God's encouragement. That is something that becomes more and more discernible the more faithful we are to walking in his presence, and the more determined we are to live with him.[11]

9. Repetitive prayers

Besides all that has just been said, one means used to foster continual prayer, especially by religious, is to repeat short phrases, often taken from or inspired by Scripture. This is done either during the time devoted to prayer or outside it, during other activities, to keep God always in mind. According to John Cassian, certain monks in Egypt in the fourth century used to repeat the following invocation ceaselessly: "O God, make haste to my rescue, Lord, come to my aid!" (Ps 70:1).

The beautiful book *The Way of a Pilgrim*[12] spread the knowledge and practice of the "Jesus Prayer" or "prayer of the heart" in the Western world. It tells of a humble Russian peasant who was moved by the exhortation in the Letter to the Thessalonians "pray without ceasing" (1 Thes 5:17), and wondered how he could put this command into practice. He traveled through Russia in search of a spiritual father who could teach him. A monk initiated him into the tradition of prayer that consists of ceaselessly repeating, "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me!," using a simple rosary of knotted woolen thread and coordinating the recital of the prayer with the rhythm of one's breathing, while looking into one's heart.

Little by little, the peasant experienced the benefits: his heart was filled with peace and purified, he felt the joy of God's presence, he received inner enlightenment about God's love, developed compassion toward everyone, and saw the world and nature with new eyes. This tradition goes back to the Egyptian monasticism of the first centuries and spread throughout Orthodox Christianity; in our days it is also spreading through the Western world.

More familiar to Western Catholics is the devotion of the Rosary, with its constant repetition of the Our Father and Hail Mary.

Today, simple repetition does not always get good press. Ours is a world that, having lost its sense of the most fundamental things in life, is permanently in search of novelty. Now, it is true that repetition can become merely mechanical and routine, but it can also mean that love is being inscribed on the soul for as long as it continues. It an intrinsic part of life: we are lucky our hearts don't get tired of constantly beating and our breathing does not get tired of its rhythm!

Rhythm, as I said earlier, plays a fundamental role in human life. It has a calming effect; it allows energy to be used for a considerable length of time without wastage or exhaustion. The rhythm of repetitive prayer enables a desire, an intention, to be expressed externally through the body and at the same time to take root in the heart. It is an acceptance of reality, of the fact of having bodies, and that our human condition is part of the rhythms of nature and life. It is openness to a deep meaning that surpasses us, going beyond the perceptions of the rational mind. It gives us access to a sort of wisdom, an intelligence of life, in a dependence on our Creator to which we consent.

Our prayer is called to become not just one activity among others but the fundamental activity of our lives, the very rhythm of our deepest existence, the breathing of our heart, so to speak. Repetitive prayers help us achieve this, since they are our human effort, our persevering quest, in the hope that God's grace will grant that for which we ask through our humble, untiring repetition of the same words.

In a talk on the Rosary given at Lourdes in October 1998, Father Timothy Radcliffe, OP, said:

> If we love someone, we know that it is not enough to tell them "I love you" just once. We will want to say it again and again, and we may hope that they wish to hear it again and again.
>
> G. K. Chesterton argued that repetition is a characteristic of the vitality of children, who like the same stories, with the same words, time and time again, not because they are bored and unimaginative but because they delight in life. Chesterton wrote: "Because children have abounding vitality, because they are in spirit fierce and free, therefore they want things repeated and unchanged. They always say, 'Do it again!'; and the grown-up person does it again until he is nearly dead, for grown-up people are not strong enough to exult in monotony. But perhaps God *is* strong enough to exult in monotony. It is possible that God says every morning, 'Do it again!' to the sun; and every evening 'Do it again!' to the moon. It may not be automatic necessity that makes all daisies alike; it may be that God makes each daisy separately, but has never got tired of making them. It may be that He has the eternal appetite of infancy; for we have sinned and grown old and our Father is younger

than we. The repetition in Nature may not be a mere recurrence; it may be a theatrical encore. Heaven may encore the bird who laid an egg" (*Orthodoxy*, chapter IV).

There is nothing in the least wrong with spending our time of prayer on these repetitive prayers, especially at moments of tiredness, difficulty in mobilizing our intellectual faculties, or else when we feel impelled by the Holy Spirit toward a prayer that, in comparison with meditation, is poorer, simpler, brought back to essentials, not relying too much on intellectual discourse or the work of imagination, but favoring the work of the heart. This repetition should be done gently, peacefully, without its becoming forced or requiring an effort (which would be counterproductive). We should be attentive to God's presence in us, while gently merging body and spirit with the form of prayer used. The rhythm of the repetition can favor our entering into a state of recollection. Being faithful to the humble but sincere search for God expressed in this prayer can give us, little by little, the grace to enter into a state of true contemplation and loving union with God.

The advantage of these repetitive prayers, besides their simplicity, is that they can progressively become a sort of habit (in the good sense of the word); that makes them a valuable resource for praying at many other moments of the day besides the time devoted to prayer properly so called. It may be when we are in the car, walking, during times of insomnia, while engaged in activities or jobs that do not take up the whole of our mind, etc.

Now some reflections on the Jesus Prayer and the Rosary.

10. The Jesus Prayer

At the basis of the Jesus Prayer lies an ancient and very beautiful spirituality of the name of Jesus, which is rooted in Scripture.[13] Jesus himself asks us to pray in his name: "If you ask anything of the Father, he will give it to you in my name" (Jn 16:23). The Acts of the Apostles often speak of the power of Jesus' name and say "there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved" (Acts 4:12).

From the earliest centuries of the Christian era, a beautiful tradition has developed of invoking the name of Jesus in prayer, whether short prayers like that used by the Russian Pilgrim or reduced to the repetition of the name Jesus alone. Many writings testify to this, such as that of St. Macarius the Egyptian, a sixth-century monk:

When I was a child I used to see women chewing betel-nuts to sweeten their saliva and remove any bad odor from their mouths. That is what the Name of Our Lord Jesus Christ should be for us: if we chew this blessed Name by pronouncing it constantly, it brings all sweetness to our souls and reveals heavenly things to us, through Him who is the food of joy, the well of salvation, the spring of living waters, the sweetness of all sweetnesses; and all evil thoughts are expelled from the soul by this name, the name of Him who is in the Heavens, Our Lord Jesus Christ, the King of kings, the Lord of all lords, heavenly reward for those who seek him with all their heart.[14]

For the practice of this prayer, consult my book *Time for God*, as well as the more extensive and excellent advice in the book *La prière de Jésus* by a monk of the Eastern Church, published in 1963 by Chevetogne.

11. The Rosary

The Rosary is very different from the Jesus Prayer, but it can be included in the category of simple repetitive prayers—prayers that, if our hearts are well-disposed, can lead us to deep communion with God and contemplative prayer.

Along with the humble supplication, “Pray for us sinners,” the Hail Mary has a dimension of praise and thanksgiving. The Rosary is also a way of following, with Mary’s help, all the riches of the mysteries of Christ, though we needn’t necessarily apply our powers of reasoning to meditate on each mystery.

It also brings the particular grace of the invocation of Mary, who introduces us into her own prayer, her own recollection, her silence and inner listening, her own communion with God. In a passage about the prayer of simplicity, Father Jean-Claude Sagne says this of the Rosary:

Vocal prayer becomes progressively a school of silence, through plunging into the silence of Mary herself. This is the singular mark of Mary’s motherly influence on the lives of the faithful: she draws those who pray it into her silence, to listen to the word of God… . The praying of the Rosary is thus an inner preparation for entering, led by the Holy Spirit, into the spiritual place that is the bosom of Mary, as a Tent of Meeting, as a space where God’s Word finds itself perfectly understood and listened to, believed, and followed.[15]

The Rosary, like the Jesus Prayer, engages the body, simply but deeply, with the rhythm of repeated words, hands counting out the Rosary beads, peaceful posture, and quiet breathing. It also engages the essential attitudes of heart and will. It offers the mind “minimal” nourishment, food that is very poor, in the simplicity of the formula used. In this way it recalls the

mind to its limitations and its essential role, which is to be a capacity for receptiveness, as in the following passage:

> The repetition is here the means of gently fixing the mind's attention, so that the heart is free to hear God's Word and keep it. The intelligence is occupied in repeating sober acts and short formulas, known by heart, to make available the deepest attention of the praying person, who is thus established in peace and confidence by the silence of listening. The prayer of simplicity contains a discreet, profound lesson on what the human mind is. It reminds us that the human mind is, first of all, an infinite capacity for receptiveness, but contains absolutely nothing of its own, until it is filled by words and images received from outside itself— from the world, from other people. It is clear from this that priority must always be accorded to listening over speaking, receiving over doing, openness to the gift over the production of a task. This permanent, basic part of the human mind, this part of passivity and dependence, is not only attested to but brought into play by the place of the body in the prayer of simplicity. By that very fact, what is taught and practiced here is also the basic spiritual attitude in Christian prayer: humility of heart in awaiting God's gift. The minimal engagement of the body in the prayer of simplicity, combined with an exercise that offers little gratification to the creative intelligence: all of this helps make this prayer a true school of contemplation for everyone. Contemplation is the prayer that is produced purely by the Holy Spirit in the praying person, and hence the prayer that is received purely as a gift from God.

In its simplicity and poverty, the Rosary is ultimately a very powerful prayer. Through Mary's gentle, motherly hands, it introduces us into those fundamental attitudes, described earlier, that make our prayer life fruitful: faith, humble hope, and simple, faithful love.

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1. Anonymous fourth-century homily, quoted in the Liturgy of the Hours, patristic reading for Friday after Ash Wednesday.
2. *The Interior Castle*, "The Fifth Mansions," chapter 3.
3. Manuscript C, folio 11 verso.
4. See all the part of Manuscript C that follows the sentence quoted here.
5. Manuscript A, folio 80 recto.
6. See, for example, the beautiful medieval text on the "Nine Ways of Prayer of St. Dominic" (*http://www.fisheaters.com/stdominic9ways.html*).
7. This question is discussed in depth by St. John of the Cross when he speaks of passing from *meditation* to *contemplation*. See, for example, *Ascent of Mount Carmel*, Book 2, chapters 12 and 13.
8. In this section I take up and slightly adapt what I wrote on this topic in my book *Called to Life* (New York: Scepter Publishers, 2008).
9. Cf. Luke 10:38–42, about Martha and Mary.
10. Matta El Maskine, *L'Expérience de Dieu dans la vie de prière*, 48.
11. Matta El Maskine, *L'Expérience de Dieu dans la vie de prière*, 248.
12. *The Way of a Pilgrim: and The Pilgrim Continues his Way*, trans. by Helen Bacovcin (New York: Image Books, 1985).
13. For a closer look at this subject, see the works of St. Bernardine of Siena.
14. Quoted by Ivan Gobry, *De saint Antoine à saint Basile* (Paris: Fayard, 1985), 258.
15. Jean-Claude Sagne, *Viens vers le Père. L'enfance spirituelle, chemin de guérison* (Paris: Editions de l'Emmanuel, 1998), 138.

CHAPTER V

Prayer of Intercession

"How great the power of prayer is, then!
It's like being a queen with constant, free access to the king's presence,
able to obtain everything she asks for."[1]

"I want your prayer to be as vast as the world."[2]

Prayer of petition is what comes to us most spontaneously: when in need, we turn to God easily to ask for his help. Of course, prayer should not be limited to that. If we want to become the "worshipers in spirit and truth" that God the Father seeks and want prayer to lead us to a profound union with God, it should be above all a prayer of praise and adoration.

That said, prayer of petition and intercession has a completely legitimate place in Christian life, as Scripture plainly shows. "First of all, then, I urge that supplications, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgivings be made for all men" (1 Tm 2:1), says St. Paul, and there are many other similar passages. The book of Psalms is the great school of prayer for Israel and the Church, and even though it concludes with psalms of praise only, it contains many petitions for God's help for the person praying or for others.

Without pretending to make an in-depth study, I shall say a few words in this chapter about the prayer of intercession. Prayer of this kind is one of the most beautiful expressions of trust in God and love for neighbor.

"Whatever you ask in my name, I will do it, that the Father may be glorified in the Son" (Jn 14:13). These words of Jesus truly invite us to present to God the needs of those close to us, of the Church, and of the whole world. In doing so (with praise and the offering of our lives), we fully exercise the "common priesthood" of all the faithful that the Second Vatican Council once again brought to light, and whose full meaning and content we are still very far from grasping.

To meditate on this vocation, it is good to contemplate the beautiful intercessors we find in the Old Testament.

We can think of Abraham. In the book of Genesis, he “haggles” with God over the minimum number of good men Sodom must have for the guilty city to be spared from destruction despite its abominable crime.[3]

We can think of several different episodes in the life of Moses—for instance, the time when on their journey through the desert the Chosen People were attacked by Amalek (for Judaism, the supreme personification of evil).[4] Joshua and his men fought on the plain until sunset, while Moses prayed continually on the summit of the hill, arms raised and supported by Aaron and Hur when his tiredness became too much for him. His prayer obtained the victory.

The most moving passage of all is undoubtedly that of Moses’ intercession for his people after their betrayal with the golden calf (Ex 32:1–14). During the forty days Moses spent on Mount Horeb, where God gave him the tablets of the law, the people committed a sin of idolatry and, according to Jewish tradition, other sins deriving from it (quarreling, debauchery). Angered, the Lord told Moses he would destroy this unfaithful people and make of him a new nation.

“Go down; for your people, whom you brought up out of the land of Egypt, have corrupted themselves; they have turned aside quickly out of the way which I commanded them; they have made for themselves a molten calf, and have worshiped it and sacrificed to it, and said, ‘These are your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt!’ I have seen this people, and behold, it is a stiff-necked people; now therefore let me alone, that my wrath may burn hot against them and I may consume them; but of you I will make a great nation” (Ex 32:7–10).

But Moses does all he can to pacify God with carefully chosen arguments:

“O Lord, why does thy wrath burn hot against thy people, whom thou hast brought forth out of the land of Egypt with great power and with a mighty hand? Why should the Egyptians say, ‘With evil intent did he bring them forth, to slay them in the mountains, and to consume them from the face of the earth’? Turn from thy fierce wrath, and repent of this evil against thy people. Remember Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, thy servants, to whom thou didst swear by thine own self, and didst say to them, ‘I will multiply your descendants as the stars of heaven, and all this land that I have promised I will give to your descendants, and they shall inherit it for ever.’ ” And the Lord repented of the evil which he thought to do to his people (Ex 32:11–14).

In this dialogue, as the rabbis have correctly pointed out, we find all the characteristics of an argument between two friends or spouses. God says to Moses, “Leave me,” before Moses has even opened his mouth; and as when

one of the children has misbehaved parents say to each other, “Look what your son has done!” each links the guilty nation to the other: “*your* people, whom *you* brought forth out of the land of Egypt.”

True, right from the start God is prepared to forgive Israel, but he wants that forgiveness to be granted through the intercession of his servant and friend Moses. God does nothing without speaking to his servants the prophets about it. Earlier, when thinking of destroying Sodom, he said to himself, “Shall I hide from Abraham what I am about to do?” (Gn 18:17).

A little later in the same chapter, we see Moses interceding again for his people still more poignantly, even asking God to erase him from the book of life if God was not going to forgive the people.

> So Moses returned to the Lord and said, “Alas, this people have sinned a great sin; they have made for themselves gods of gold. But now, if thou wilt forgive their sin—and if not, blot me, I pray thee, out of thy book which thou hast written” (Ex 32:31–32).

Moses became God’s friend. In the tent of meeting, “the Lord used to speak to Moses face to face, as a man speaks to his friend” (Ex 33:11). This friendship with God conferred great power on Moses’ prayer.

We are all invited to enter into this friendship with God. In the Gospel, Jesus says to his Apostles:

> No longer do I call you servants, for the servant does not know what his master is doing; but I have called you friends, for all that I have heard from my Father I have made known to you (Jn 15:15).

On reading this verse in the Gospel, I sometimes say to myself that Jesus really has put himself in a difficult position by saying this to us. One can refuse something a servant asks for, but it is impossible to refuse a friend anything.

This friendship implies a true desire to be faithful on our part. “You are my friends if you do what I command you,” Jesus says in the preceding verse.

But there is a beautiful mystery there, a magnificent door that is opened to us to give power to our prayer.

We are called to do God’s will in everything, because that will is our life and our happiness, and also because there is a deep joy to be found in doing the will of someone we love and trust completely. But it is beautiful to understand that this is not a one-way thing: God asks us to do his will so that he can also do ours, so that he can have the joy of granting our prayers. One of the desert fathers said:

Obedience responds to obedience. If someone obeys
God, God responds to that person's request.[5]

Shortly before St. Thérèse of Lisieux died, she said with her usual simplicity and daring:

Our good God will have to fulfill all my wishes in Heaven, because I have never done my own will on earth.[6]

1. God refuses nothing to people who refuse him nothing

There is an amazing passage in something written by Jean-Jacques Olier, an important figure in the renewal of the priesthood in France in the seventeenth century (founder of the Sulpicians, he played a leading role in the creation of seminaries and the renewal of parishes). In a set of rules for seminaries, which he saw above all as places of formation in prayer, he speaks of the importance of prayer and the basic need to form future priests in it.[7] Basing himself on a passage from St. Gregory the Great, he goes so far as to say:

According to St. Gregory, before being a priest a man should have reached such familiarity with God that he cannot be refused: so that the person who is admitted to conversation with God and has not the experience of having the power over him to appease him when he is angered, should not become a priest, nor be allowed to be a pastor in the Church, one of whose main duties, after that of his own justification and the love of his neighbor, is to soften the wrath of God and reconcile the world to him.

What would the superiors of seminaries today make of this criterion for admission to the priesthood? The language may shock us, but there is an obvious allusion to the prayer of Moses and a beautiful, and correct, insight into the priest's role as intercessor, his first task being to beg God ceaselessly to have mercy on his people.

Other beautiful passages from the Old Testament encourage us to make intercession: for example, this one, inviting us to give God no rest until he has fulfilled all his promises of salvation for Jerusalem:

Upon your walls, O Jerusalem, I have set watchmen; all the day and all the night they shall never be silent. You who put the Lord in remembrance, take no rest, and give him no rest until he establishes Jerusalem and makes it a praise in the earth (Is 62:6–7).

The verse before this is a magnificent expression of the spousal love between God and Israel:

For as a young man marries a virgin, so shall your rebuilder marry you, and as the bridegroom rejoices over the bride, so shall your God rejoice over you (Is 62:5).

The dialogue with God in prayer can play on different registers: that of friendship, nuptial union, the relationship of father and child. In the Gospel, Jesus, while teaching us the "Our Father," lays much stress on the power of the prayer addressed to their heavenly Father by those he has adopted as his children.

If you then, who are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask him (Mt 7:11).

Intercession for the salvation of the whole world is a fundamental part of the Church's ministry. Whether speaking as friend, spouse, or child of God, we should beg God unceasingly to have mercy on the world. We find countless examples in the saints' lives of their role as intercessors, and of the beautiful spiritual motherhood or fatherhood that is expressed in it. Think of St. Dominic, who spent whole nights in prayer, invoking God in these terms: "My God, my mercy, what will become of sinners?" Before entering Carmel, St. Thérèse of Lisieux, prayed so fervently as an adolescent for the murderer Pranzini that she obtained his conversion at the very moment he was mounting the scaffold; and in her autobiography she calls the man whom the press was calling a monster "my first child."[8]

Among so many other, similar instances, I cannot resist quoting an extract from the spiritual diary of St. Faustina Kowalska, to whom Jesus revealed the secrets of his merciful Heart. Here we find a modern and very feminine version of "holy haggling" very similar to that of Abraham and Moses:

This morning after completing my spiritual exercises, I began at once to crochet. I sensed a stillness in my heart; I sensed that Jesus was resting in it. That deep and sweet consciousness of God's presence prompted me to say to the Lord, "O Most Holy Trinity dwelling in my heart, I beg You: grant the grace of conversion to as many souls as the number of stitches that I will make today with this crochet hook." Then I heard these words in my soul: **My daughter, too great are your demands.** "Jesus, you know that for You it is easier to grant much rather than a little." **That is so, it is less difficult for Me to grant a soul much rather than a little, but every conversion of a sinful soul demands sacrifice.** "Well, Jesus, I offer You this whole-hearted work of mine; this offering does not seem to me to be too small for such a large number of souls; You know, Jesus, that for thirty years You were saving souls by just this kind of work. And since holy obedience forbids me to perform great penances and mortifications, therefore I ask You, Lord: accept these mere nothings, stamped with the seal of obedience, as great things." Then I heard a voice in my soul: **My dear daughter, I comply with your request.**[9]

2. Intercession, a place for struggle and growth

While our Lord desires to associate us with his redeeming work through this beautiful ministry of intercession that he offers to Christians, intercession is also a path of growth and personal purification. It is a place of graces and joy, but also a place for struggle and conversion.

When praying for people whom we love and who are close to us, we practice intercession spontaneously. Obviously there is nothing wrong with that, but it could leave us enclosed in a rather small circle. Our hearts need to be enlarged to the measure of God's. It is good, then, for us to open ourselves to other subjects for intercession, whom we might not think of on our own but whom our Lord wants to entrust to us. This can wonderfully enlarge our hearts and broaden the horizons of our lives. Interceding is not only pleading for someone who is part of our universe but entering into the intercession of Jesus himself, who does not cease to present all the needs of mankind to his Father.

I have met many people who, in sometimes unexpected ways, have received a forceful call from the Holy Spirit to include and support certain intentions in their prayers and offerings: for priests, young people in difficulties, persecuted Christians, the people of Israel, some specific category of sinners, the dying, etc. Openness to these appeals from the Holy Spirit can give meaning and fruitfulness to the lives of numerous people who, lacking that, would sometimes feel useless—and there is nothing worse. Let us ask God, then, to enlighten us about the people he wishes to entrust to our prayer and our love.

3. When God does not seem to hear us

A certain question often arises concerning the prayer of intercession: what is to be said about all the times when God seems deaf to our prayers? They seem to belie the passages in the Gospel in which Jesus tells us we will obtain everything we ask for with faith. What is the meaning of these times when prayer goes unanswered? They are not easy to endure or to understand; and I think there will always remain some element of mystery in God's wisdom. While fully respecting that, I nevertheless venture a few remarks.

Not a single one of our prayers is ever lost. Sooner or later, each will be answered; perhaps not at the time or in the way we imagine, but when and as God wants, in his plans that surpass our understanding. Our prayers are not always answered as we would want, but the fact of expressing them always brings us closer to God, leads us forward on our inner journey, and attracts a certain grace that we shall one day see clearly and that will then fill us with wonder.

There is an example in the second letter to the Corinthians. Three times St. Paul begged our Lord to deliver him from his "thorn in the flesh," but the Lord replied, "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness" (2 Cor 12:9). Paul's petition was not granted materially, but his prayer was not in vain— far from it! It made him enter into dialogue with God, and that enabled him to penetrate more deeply into God's wisdom. What is most important about intercession is not always its material object, but rather the connection with God established and developed by means of it. That connection will always bear fruit, both for ourselves and for the people for whom we pray.

God does not always answer us in the way we would like, since sometimes we need to realize, in specific instances, that we cannot manipulate God. That is what all pagan forms of worship attempt to do. We can obtain everything from God by trust and prayer, but God remains the absolute master of his gifts, and they are always totally gratuitous— unmerited and given at his choosing, not ours.

God does not lend himself to any kind of manipulation, blackmail, human mode of calculation, or claim. It is good that we experience this fact from time to time, so that our relationship with him is simple, trusting, familiar, and daring in the manner of a daughter or son, yet at the same time respects his absolute sovereignty. God does not have to render any account to mankind. Here is one of the paradoxes of Christian life: we are called to live with God in a tender familiarity that gives us full power over his fatherly heart; but we can only enter into that familiar relationship with absolute, sometimes agonizing respect for his sovereign transcendence and freedom. In the letter to the Romans (9:20), reflecting on the drama of the unbelief of part of Israel, which he finds so painful, St. Paul says: "Who are you, a man, to answer back to God? Will what is molded say to its molder, 'Why have you made me thus?' "

We can assert no “rights” over God. Sometimes we have the feeling that because we have tried so hard, exerted ourselves so much for him, God does owe us something—we have a certain right to his blessings and graces. The Gospel parable of the useless servants (Lk 17:7–10) reminds us that that isn’t so. When we have accomplished something good, when we have done our duty, we should thank God for it, but beware of feeling it gives us any kind of privilege. Our good works do not endow us with any “right” over either God or other people, despite what we often tend to think and whether we admit it or not.

It is salutary for us to maintain a lively awareness of the absolute gratuity of God’s gifts at all times. Otherwise our relationship with him, as well as with other people, can get on the wrong track that leads the logic of love to deteriorate into the logic of human calculations. When God answers our prayers, it is not by virtue of our merits or qualities but by virtue of his mercy and freely bestowed love. The answer to a prayer is not something owed us; it is a gift.

Our prayer should be persevering, trusting, even daring, but always infused with humble submission to God’s will. Our petitions are often accompanied by certain human expectations that are not always completely pure. Our suffering at not receiving an immediate answer, the need to endure and persevere, and the invitation to patience, work in us a necessary process of purification and deepening, and this process will make our prayer truer, more in accordance with God’s wisdom, and therefore ultimately more effective and more profound. This whole process of purifying and educating our desires and wishes is an important element of our spiritual growth and hence of our prayer.

Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness; for we do not know how to pray as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with sighs too deep for words. And he who searches the hearts of men knows what is the mind of the Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints according to the will of God (Rom 8:26–27).

To conclude these reflections, I note that one of the most effective ways to undertake this work of purification, as well as to grow in humility and trust, is to make our prayer of intercession, no matter what its “results,” in the mode of thanksgiving. It is striking to see how St. Paul in his letters always combines petition and thanksgiving in one and the same movement.

Continue steadfastly in prayer, being watchful in it with thanksgiving; and pray for us also, that God may open to us a door for the word, to declare the mystery of Christ (Col 4:2–3).

Have no anxiety about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God (Phil 4:6).

First of all, then, I urge that supplications, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgivings be made for all men (1 Tm 2:1).

Intercession itself should always be done “with thanksgiving.” That is necessary for our prayer to have its full depth, truth, and fruitfulness, for it to be a source of blessings for us and for others. There is nothing like thanksgiving and gratitude to purify our hearts and make us experience this beatitude:

Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God (Mt 5:8).

Blessed be his Name forever! Amen.

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1. St. Thérèse of Lisieux, Manuscript C, folio 25 recto.
2. Words of Jesus to Sister Marie of the Trinity, in *Consens à n’être rien* (Paris: Arfuyen, 2008), 77.
3. Gn 18:22–23.
4. It is said in the book of Exodus that the Lord will have war on Amalek from generation to generation (Ex 17:16), which is not said of any other nation.
5. Quoted in J.-C. Guy, *Paroles des anciens, Apothegmes des Pères du Désert* (Paris: Le Seuil, 1976).
6. *Derniers entretiens*, dated July 13, 1897.
7. Jean-Jacques Olier, *Vivre pour Dieu en Jésus-Christ, textes choisis* (Paris: Cerf, 1995), 82.
8. Manuscript A, folio 46 recto.
9. *Divine Mercy in My Soul: Diary of Saint Maria Faustina Kowalska* (Stockbridge, Mass: Marian Press, 2013), 373–374 (February 16, 1937).